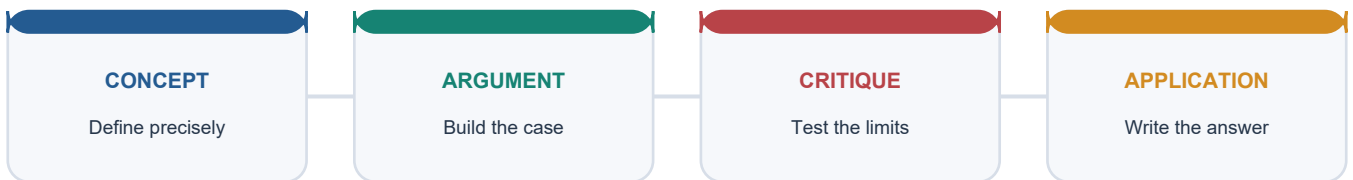


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Nature of Religious Language - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Nature of Religious Language - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-10 **Syllabus clause, verbatim:** *Nature of Religious Language : Analogical and Symbolic; Cognitivist and Non-cognitive.* **Evidence discipline:** doctrine, attribution and previous-year wording are controlled by repository owners and local sources. Model answers are independent learner practice, never official UPSC keys. **Terminology rule:** English-first. Sanskrit and Pali terms follow the English concept immediately.

Package counts

Component	Count
Visual-first Basic sessions	20
Original hard MCQs	32 (24 core + 8 remedial)
Verified owner PYQs	14
Original Mains models	6 (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)
Optional Advanced modules	4
Consolidated register cards	20
ASCII master panels	25

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Exact ownership and cross-topic firewall

This clause owns **how religious expressions signify** and **whether they are truth-apt**. It covers analogy, symbol, negation, indication, verification, falsification, non-cognitive use and bounded Indian semantic comparisons.

Owned here	Boundary retained
univocal, equivocal, analogical, symbolic, metaphorical, mythical and apophatic modes	complete nature/attributes of God remain with Notions of God
verification, falsification and cognitive content	the full Logical Positivist programme remains in Paper I
language-game, grammar and form of life as religious-language analysis	Later Wittgenstein's complete philosophy remains in Paper I
performative, expressive, prescriptive and self-involving uses	faith/revelation warrant remains with Reason, Revelation and Faith
ineffability as a semantic problem	experience phenomenology remains with Religious Experience
semantic conditions of plural reference	full pluralism remains with Religious Pluralism
Indian negation, indication, injunction and conditional predication	complete school doctrines remain with Paper I owners

Controlling distinction: meaningfulness does not entail empirical factuality. An utterance may be symbolic, performative or morally significant; the further question is whether it also asserts truth.

Source and coverage control

- Canonical owner: complete Section 0-19, including all ten owner dossiers, comparison grids, traps, directive decoder and quotation discipline.
- Optional Advanced dossier: four second-order debates only; no core answer depends on them.
- Verified owner load: fourteen Paper II question-parts from 2018-2025.
- Local John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion*, PDF pp. 93-118, controls the two main issues, analogy, verification and non-cognitive theories.
- Local *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion*, PDF pp. 232-256, controls religious-language realism and Wittgensteinian boundaries.
- Indian parallels are bounded structural comparisons; Advaita, Mīmāṃsā, Buddhist and Jain owners retain full doctrinal authority.
- Live ICML 2026 material illustrates Sanskrit-English semantic drift only; it is not evidence for a doctrine.

Conceptual origin and minimum chronology

CLASSICAL PROBLEM

Maimonides, Guide I.50-60 -> negations and attributes of action
Aquinas, Summa Theologiae I q.13 -> analogy and divine names
Scotus, Ordinatio I d.3 -> univocity of the concept of being

↓

MODERN ANALYTIC PRESSURE

Ayer, Language, Truth and Logic -> verification challenge
1950-51 Flew-Hare-Mitchell -> falsification / blik / defeasible trust
1955 Braithwaite -> moral-policy account
1957 Ramsey -> model and qualifier
Austin -> speech acts; 1963 Evans -> self-involving language

↓

CONTEMPORARY SYNTHESIS

analogy + symbol + apophasis + speech acts + cognitive spectrum
-> mixed realism: assertion, symbolic mode and commitment can coexist

Learning roadmap

1. Separate HOW from WHETHER. 2. State the univocal/equivocal dilemma. 3-5. Master Aquinas, later Thomists and Scotus. 6-8. Learn negation, Tillich and Ramsey. 9. Speech acts and secular/religious use. 10-12. Verification, falsification and the full cognitive spectrum. 13-14. Braithwaite and qualified Wittgensteinian use. 15-16. Advaita and bounded Indian semantics. 17-18. Symbolism and mysticism. 19. Pluralism bridge. 20. Synthesis and answer architecture.

SESSION 1 - TWO AXES: SEMANTIC MODE AND TRUTH-STATUS

DEFINITION

The problem asks two independent questions: **HOW** a transcendent predicate signifies and **WHETHER** the utterance is truth-apt or primarily performs another function.

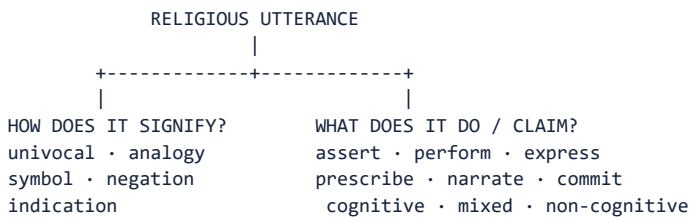
ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Religious language is misclassified whenever semantic mode is inferred from truth-status: an utterance may be symbolic in mode and cognitive in intent.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **HOW axis**
- **WHETHER axis**
- **truth-aptness**
- **semantic mode**
- **speech function**
- **mixed account**

VISUAL - TWO AXES: SEMANTIC MODE AND TRUTH-STATUS



CONTROL: "God is good" may be ANALOGICAL + COGNITIVE.

Simple start. One sentence can occupy several categories. "God is good" may refer analogically, assert a truth, express trust and commit conduct.

Mode/use	Function	Truth status
Literal/univocal	same conceptual sense	cognitive but anthropomorphic risk
Analogical	ordered similarity through participation/proportion	qualified cognitive realism
Symbolic	participation and disclosure	symbolic realism or non-cognitive use
Negative	denies creaturely limits	cognitively restrictive; vacuity risk
Performative	enacts vow, confession or relation	different success-conditions; presuppositions may be true
Expressive/prescriptive	attitude or conduct	primarily non-cognitive, not meaningless

Current illustration, not doctrine. The verified ICML 2026 Sanskrit-English translation poster reports dictionary, morpho-syntactic and glossary constraints to reduce semantic drift. It illustrates that meaning is context-sensitive; it proves no theory of God-talk.

Verified item: Jintao Ma et al., "AI as Cultural Mediation: Agentic Sanskrit-English Translation with Linguistic Grounding," ICML 2026 *Culture x AI* workshop poster, 10 July 2026. The official page supports only the translation-mediation illustration.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: semantic mode and truth-status are independent. **Evidence:** Aquinas's analogical "God is good" remains truth-apt. **Analysis:** analogy qualifies *how* goodness is predicated without cancelling assertion. **Qualification:** whether the assertion is warranted is a further epistemic question.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not treat "non-literal" as "non-cognitive".
- Do not call every meaningful utterance empirically factual.
- Do not collapse speech function into semantic reference.

MINI RECAP

Two axes first; all later thinkers answer one or both.

SESSION 2 - THE UNIVOCAL-EQUIVOCAL DILEMMA

DEFINITION

Univocity uses the same concept for God and creatures; equivocity severs the meanings. The problem is to preserve reference without domesticating transcendence.

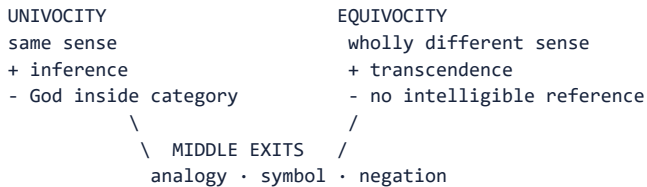
ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The classical problem is not whether words occur, but whether enough semantic continuity remains for inference without making God a finite instance.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- univocity
- equivocity
- anthropomorphism
- semantic continuity
- transcendence
- middle way

VISUAL - THE UNIVOCAL-EQUIVOCAL DILEMMA



Univocity protects valid reasoning: if "good" changes meaning completely, an inference from creaturely goodness to God equivocates. But unqualified sameness appears to place God within a finite genus.

Equivocity protects transcendence but destroys the bridge. If "good" of God shares nothing with creaturely goodness, the word no longer teaches.

Three families answer: analogy retains ordered similarity; symbol mediates participatory disclosure; apophasis denies limitations. Scotus instead defends semantic univocity while reintroducing ontological difference through finite/infinite modes.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: complete equivocity defeats theology. **Evidence:** Scotus's demand for a stable concept in inference.

Analysis: a middle term must carry across premises. **Qualification:** semantic continuity need not imply identical modes of being.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not begin with thinker names before stating the dilemma.
- Do not say univocity automatically means ontological sameness.
- Do not call analogy a decorative metaphor.

MINI RECAP

The whole clause trades three goods: inference, transcendence and non-vacuity.

SESSION 3 - AQUINAS I: ESSENTIAL AND EMINENT PREDICATION

DEFINITION

Aquinas holds that pure perfections such as goodness are present in God **essentially and eminently**, while human signification remains creature-derived and inadequate.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Aquinas protects realism by separating the perfection truly signified from the finite manner in which human language signifies it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Aquinas
- pure perfection
- essentially and eminently
- res significata
- modus significandi

- causal participation

VISUAL - AQUINAS I: ESSENTIAL AND EMINENT PREDICATION

CREATURELY EFFECTS

display goodness / wisdom / being
 |
 | causal dependence + likeness
 v

DIVINE CAUSE

perfection present ESSENTIALLY AND EMINENTLY

res significata -> applies truly

modus significandi -> remains creaturely and inadequate

In *Summa Theologiae* I q.13, Aquinas refuses the reduction "God is good" merely means "God causes goodness." God causes goodness because goodness pre-exists in God according to a higher mode.

The **thing signified** (*res significata*) is the perfection itself and applies truly. The **mode of signification** (*modus significandi*) reflects how finite knowers encounter perfection and is inadequate to divine being.

Causal participation grounds the relation: an effect resembles its cause without reproducing the cause's mode. The account is cognitive and realist, though analogical.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: divine goodness is genuinely predicated. **Evidence:** Aquinas's res/modus distinction. **Analysis:** it secures truth while blocking a creaturely mode. **Qualification:** critics still ask how content is fixed without prior knowledge of God.

UPSC TRAPS

- Never paraphrase Aquinas as cause-only attribution.
- Keep "essentially and eminently" with the technical pair.
- Analogy qualifies predication; it does not make the sentence non-cognitive.

MINI RECAP

True perfection, inadequate mode: that is Aquinas's core formula.

SESSION 4 - AQUINAS II: ATTRIBUTION, PROPORTIONALITY AND THE TAXONOMY CAUTION

DEFINITION

Later Thomists systematise analogy into attribution and proportionality; the familiar pair is especially Cajetanian and must not be presented as Aquinas's fixed two-part taxonomy.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Use attribution and proportionality as explanatory tools, but anchor Aquinas in essential-and-eminent predication and the res/modus distinction.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- attribution
- proportionality
- healthy example
- Cajetan
- ordered predication
- taxonomy caution

VISUAL - AQUINAS II: ATTRIBUTION, PROPORTIONALITY AND THE TAXONOMY CAUTION

ATTRIBUTION

healthy animal (primary)
-> medicine as cause
-> complexion as sign

PROPORTIONALITY

God : infinite goodness :: creature : finite goodness

CAUTION -> later Thomist / especially Cajetanian systematisation

Attribution orders secondary uses to a primary subject. "Healthy" belongs primarily to an animal and derivatively to medicine as cause or complexion as sign. The example illustrates ordered predication; divine goodness cannot be reduced to it.

Proportionality says a perfection belongs to God according to the infinite divine mode as it belongs to a creature according to a finite mode.

The two are useful in examinations, provided the attribution is historically qualified. The metaphysical engine remains causal participation, not resemblance alone.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: analogy has ordered content. **Evidence:** later Thomist attribution/proportionality. **Analysis:** the taxonomy shows two relations rather than sheer ambiguity. **Qualification:** it systematises Aquinas and does not replace his own essential-and-eminent account.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not say medicine is healthy in exactly the animal's sense.
- Do not treat the healthy example as the whole theory of divine goodness.
- Attribute the pair cautiously to later Thomism.

MINI RECAP

Taxonomy helps; historical over-attribution hurts.

SESSION 5 - SCOTUS: SEMANTIC UNIVOCITY AND INTRINSIC MODES

DEFINITION

Scotus requires a common concept of being and pure perfection for valid inference, while finite and infinite intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Scotist univocity is semantic, not the claim that God and creatures exist in the same ontological way.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Duns Scotus
- univocity of being
- certain and doubtful concepts
- intrinsic modes
- finite/infinite
- inference

VISUAL - SCOTUS: SEMANTIC UNIVOCITY AND INTRINSIC MODES

CERTAIN: God is a BEING
DOUBTFUL: finite or infinite?
|
v
concept "being" must be neutral/common
|
v
INTRINSIC MODES restore difference
finite creature != infinite God

The certain-and-doubtful argument says one may be certain that God is a being while doubtful whether God is finite or infinite. The certain concept cannot be identical with either doubtful specification; "being" must be conceptually common.

Scotus denies that being is a genus containing God and creatures. Infinity and finitude are intrinsic modes, not species within one class.

His objection to analogy is that without a common conceptual core every inference equivocates. The Thomist replies that causal ordering supplies continuity without flattening the Creator-creature difference.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: inference needs semantic stability. **Evidence:** Scotus's certain/doubtful argument. **Analysis:** a neutral concept carries reasoning across premises. **Qualification:** the neutral concept does not imply a shared ontological mode or genus.

UPSC TRAPS

- Never call Scotus's univocity ontological sameness.
- Do not present "univocity caused secularity" as settled history.
- Do not let the Thomist reply remain unstated.

MINI RECAP

Scotus buys inference; Aquinas fears anthropomorphism.

SESSION 6 - MAIMONIDES AND THE NEGATIVE WAY

DEFINITION

Maimonides rejects positive essential attributes of God and permits disciplined negations plus attributes of action.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Negative theology protects transcendence only if its denials and action-language retain enough content to distinguish God from nothing.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Maimonides
- via negativa
- negative attributes
- attributes of action
- divine simplicity
- vacuity

VISUAL - MAIMONIDES AND THE NEGATIVE WAY

POSITIVE ESSENCE? -> threatens multiplicity in God -> REJECT
NEGATION -> not ignorant / not powerless
ACTION-LANGUAGE -> "merciful" from effects
|
v
transcendence protected
but VACUITY pressure remains

In *Guide for the Perplexed* 1.50-60, a positive quality seems to add a component to divine essence. Maimonides therefore allows negation and descriptions of action.

"God is merciful" may name the effect of divine action without positing creature-like emotion. "God is not ignorant" excludes error but does not define the essence.

The method gains purity and loses positive content. Unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing. The answer must therefore show how tradition, action and ordered denial constrain speech.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: apophysis has determinate negative content. **Evidence:** Maimonides's negations and attributes of action.

Analysis: false creaturely models are excluded while effects remain describable. **Qualification:** negative content alone may not identify a worship-worthy referent.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not say Maimonides permits ordinary positive essential predicates.
- Do not confuse attributes of action with attributes inhering in essence.
- Always face the vacuity objection.

MINI RECAP

Negation secures purity and risks silence.

SESSION 7 - TILLICH: SYMBOL, PARTICIPATION AND BEING-ITSELF

DEFINITION

Tillichian symbols point beyond themselves, participate in what they indicate, disclose reality and self, arise collectively and may grow or die.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A religious symbol is not a replaceable sign: its claim to meaning rests on participation and self-transcendence.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Tillich
- sign/symbol
- participation
- being-itself
- ultimate concern
- demonic

VISUAL - TILlich: SYMBOL, PARTICIPATION AND BEING-ITSELF

SIGN	SYMBOL
conventional pointer	points + PARTICIPATES
replaceable	opens reality and self
no transformative depth	transforms; grows; may die

GOD -> not a being -> BEING-ITSELF
finite symbol claiming ultimacy -> IDOLATRY / DEMONIC

Tillich rejects God as one being among beings. Religious symbols mediate ultimate concern and open depths inaccessible to literal description.

A flag's participation in collective identity is a preliminary analogy; religious symbolism claims deeper participation. Symbols cannot simply be manufactured by decree and can lose power historically.

Tillich's caution is essential. He treated "God is being-itself" as a non-symbolic anchor, later modified the position, and interpreters dispute its status. A wholly symbolic theory faces self-reference and vague-reference pressures.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: symbolic reference can be realist. **Evidence:** Tillich's participation and being-itself. **Analysis:** the symbol mediates rather than copies its referent. **Qualification:** participation needs constraints, and the proposed non-symbolic anchor is disputed.

UPSC TRAPS

- Never call symbol a mere sign.
- Never call God "the highest being" in Tillich.
- Preserve the modified/disputed exception.

MINI RECAP

Participation explains depth; idolatry marks the failure.

SESSION 8 - RAMSEY, METAPHOR AND MYTHIC DISCLOSURE

DEFINITION

Ramsey's model-and-qualifier account explains how ordinary language is stretched toward disclosure without becoming either literal identity or complete equivocation.

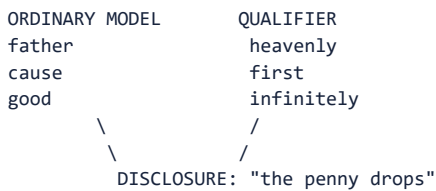
ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Religious language remains connected to ordinary models, while qualifiers force those models beyond their familiar limits.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Ian Ramsey
- model
- qualifier
- disclosure situation
- metaphor
- myth

VISUAL - RAMSEY, METAPHOR AND MYTHIC DISCLOSURE



A **model** supplies ordinary content; a **qualifier** develops and corrects it until a disclosure situation occurs. The qualifier does not erase the model but prevents literal enclosure.

Metaphor transfers a pattern imaginatively; myth narratively organises identity and value. Neither is identical to Tillich's participatory symbol, though all can disclose.

Ramsey explains why religious language is parasitic on ordinary language rather than a separate instrument. Its risk resembles analogy: how much content survives stretching?

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: ordinary language can disclose transcendence without univocal identity. **Evidence:** Ramsey's father/heavenly and cause/first structure. **Analysis:** the qualifier both preserves and revises the model. **Qualification:** disclosure remains interpretive and needs public constraints.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not say the qualifier cancels ordinary content.
- Do not collapse metaphor, myth and symbol.
- Do not use "disclosure" as a substitute for argument.

MINI RECAP

Model gives content; qualifier prevents reduction.

SESSION 9 - SPEECH ACTS: AUSTIN, EVANS AND SECULAR/RELIGIOUS USE

DEFINITION

Religious utterances often have locutionary content, illocutionary force and perlocutionary effects; their self-involvement does not automatically cancel assertion.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Secular and religious uses differ characteristically in function, referent, verification and commitment-not in vocabulary.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Austin
- locution/illocution/perlocution
- performative
- Donald Evans
- self-involvement
- felicity conditions

VISUAL - SPEECH ACTS: AUSTIN, EVANS AND SECULAR/RELIGIOUS USE

"I take refuge" / "I baptise" / vow / blessing
|
+--- locution: words/proposition
+--- illocution: act performed
+--- perlocution: effect on hearer/community
|
v
SELF-INVOLVEMENT -> speaker constituted/committed

J. L. Austin prevents a category mistake: not every utterance is a failed description. A vow succeeds or fails under felicity conditions. Donald Evans applies this to religion: confession, prayer and blessing constitute relationships and commit conduct.

Axis	Characteristic secular use	Characteristic religious use
function	describe/predict/instruct	worship/confess/bless/vow
referent	empirical particulars	transcendent/non-ostensible
verification	determinate public procedures	contested, experiential or eschatological
self-involvement	often detachable	typically committing

Continuity matters: religious speech borrows ordinary words and remains subject to logic. A courtroom oath is secular and performative; scripture may contain ordinary historical claims.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: religious meaning includes illocutionary force. **Evidence:** Austin's performatives and Evans's self-involvement. **Analysis:** testing a vow only for empirical truth misses what it enacts. **Qualification:** the act can presuppose truth and remain open to criticism.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not say every secular sentence is descriptive.
- Do not infer "performative" means "non-cognitive".
- Do not search for a special religious vocabulary.

MINI RECAP

Use, not vocabulary; overlap, not two sealed languages.

SESSION 10 - AYER AND THE VERIFICATION CHALLENGE

DEFINITION

Ayer treats synthetic statements as factually meaningful only if experience can verify or probabilistically support them; transcendent God-talk fails his test.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Verificationism imposes evidential discipline but cannot simply equate the limits of empirical testing with the limits of meaning.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- A. J. Ayer
- verification principle
- strong/weak verification
- analytic/synthetic
- self-application
- over-restriction

VISUAL - AYER AND THE VERIFICATION CHALLENGE

ANALYTIC? -> true by meaning

SYNTHETIC? -> experience must count for it

"God exists" -> no possible empirical test

|

AYER: literally meaningless

|

OBJECTIONS: criterion self-application + excessive exclusions

Weak verification does not demand conclusive proof but still requires possible experiential support. Ayer therefore calls metaphysics meaningless rather than false.

The criterion faces two pressures. It appears neither analytically true nor straightforwardly empirically verifiable. It also excludes many historical, theoretical, ethical and modal sentences ordinarily treated as meaningful.

The correct reply is not that evidence is irrelevant. Later debates broaden verification, distinguish factual from performative meaning, and ask whether religious claims are vulnerable to reasons at all.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Ayer's criterion excludes transcendent assertions. **Evidence:** the analytic/synthetic and experiential test.

Analysis: the attack targets factual meaning, not merely truth. **Qualification:** the criterion's own status and scope remain disputed.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not say Ayer proves God does not exist.
- Do not confuse weak verification with conclusive proof.
- Do not answer evidential criticism only by listing non-descriptive uses.

MINI RECAP

Ayer forces the question; he does not settle every kind of meaning.

SESSION 11 - FALSIFICATION: FLEW, HARE, MITCHELL AND HICK

DEFINITION

The falsification debate asks what would count against religious assertion and distinguishes evidential immunity, non-factual orientation, defeasible trust and delayed verification.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The strongest cognitivist reply to Flew concedes that counterevidence counts without requiring commitment to collapse at the first anomaly.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Antony Flew
- invisible gardener
- thousand qualifications
- Hare's blik
- Mitchell's partisan
- eschatological verification

VISUAL - FALSIFICATION: FLEW, HARE, MITCHELL AND HICK

FLEW: what would count AGAINST divine love?
endless qualifications -> assertion "dies"
|
+-- HARE: blik -> important but non-factual
+-- MITCHELL: trust + adverse evidence really counts
+-- HICK: truth-apt now; confirmable at journey's end

Flew adapts Wisdom's invisible gardener: if every failure is qualified away, the words retain grammar but lose evidential consequence.

Hare's paranoid student illustrates a *blik*, a basic way of seeing the world that may be sane or insane and profoundly practical without functioning as an ordinary hypothesis.

Basil Mitchell's partisan trusts the Stranger despite disturbing evidence but admits it counts against trust. His model is **defeasible cognition**, not immunity. John Hick answers verification from another direction through **eschatological verification**: the celestial city may confirm one traveller at the end, though present falsification remains difficult.

View	Evidence role	Truth status
Flew	demands possible disconfirmation	critic of empty cognition
Hare	evidence does not test the blik as fact	non-factual orientation
Mitchell	adverse evidence counts but may be outweighed	cognitive trust
Hick	future confirmation possible	cognitive, eschatological

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: faith can remain cognitive without decisive present falsifiability. **Evidence:** Mitchell's partisan. **Analysis:** contrary evidence affects warrant rather than becoming irrelevant. **Qualification:** if no conceivable evidence could ever matter, Flew's vacuity charge returns.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not call Hare and Mitchell the same reply.
- Do not call Hick's claim meaningless now.
- Do not turn resilient trust into total evidential immunity.

MINI RECAP

The debate is about vulnerability to reasons, not one mechanical test.

SESSION 12 - THE TEN-POINT COGNITIVE SPECTRUM AND MIXED REALISM

DEFINITION

Cognitivism/non-cognitivism is a spectrum of truth-aptness, reference and use, not two boxes.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Religious utterances are often assertoric, symbolic and performative at once; a mixed account preserves realist intent and practical force.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **literal realism**
- **analogical realism**
- **symbolic realism**
- **eschatological verification**
- **mixed speech act**
- **non-realism**

VISUAL - THE TEN-POINT COGNITIVE SPECTRUM AND MIXED REALISM

1 literal realism	Alston / Swinburne
2 analogical realism	Aquinas
3 symbolic realism	Tillich / Ramsey
4 eschatological realism	Hick
5 mixed speech acts	Evans / Alston
6 meaning-in-use	Wittgensteinian / Phillips [contested]
7 moral-conative	Braithwaite
8 blik	Hare
9 fictionalism	Cupitt / Le Poidevin
10 hostile elimination	Ayer

A strong answer locates thinkers rather than lumping them. Analogical and symbolic modes can remain cognitive. Non-cognitive theories range from constructive moral use to hostile meaninglessness.

The two symmetrical objections are crucial. Cognitivism faces reference and verification/falsification pressure. Non-cognitivism faces reductionism: it misdescribes believers and cannot explain why a moral policy should be adopted if the sustaining stories disclose nothing real.

The mixed position distinguishes proposition, mode of reference, illocutionary force and communal grammar. It preserves assertion but rejects unqualified literalism; it recognises commitment but rejects insulation.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: the binary is structurally inadequate. **Evidence:** Tillich and Evans occupy mixed positions unlike Ayer or Braithwaite. **Analysis:** truth-aptness and force vary independently. **Qualification:** a mixed label must still specify evidence, referent and the primary function in context.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not place Ayer, Braithwaite, Hare and Phillips in one box.
- Do not call symbol or performance automatically non-cognitive.
- Do not invoke "mixed" to avoid taking a position.

MINI RECAP

Map the spectrum, then defend your location.

SESSION 13 - BRAITHWAITE: MORAL POLICY, STORIES AND REDUCTIONISM

DEFINITION

Braithwaite interprets religious assertion as commitment to a moral policy-especially agape-sustained by stories rather than ordinary factual description.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Braithwaite correctly identifies moral self-involvement and incorrectly treats one illocutionary force as the whole semantic content.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- R. B. Braithwaite
- moral-conative
- agapeistic policy
- religious stories
- self-involvement
- reductionism

VISUAL - BRAITHWAITE: MORAL POLICY, STORIES AND REDUCTIONISM

```
"GOD IS LOVE"  
  |  
BRAITHWAITE'S PRIMARY FORCE  
  v  
I intend to live AGAPEISTICALLY  
  +-- stories supply models/motivation  
  +-- practical seriousness retained  
  -  realist reference deleted/reduced
```

Braithwaite's 1955 account is constructive non-cognitivism. Unlike Ayer, he saves meaning; unlike Hare, he focuses on moral intention; unlike Wittgensteinian grammar, he specifies one dominant policy.

Strengths: creed-conduct connection, narrative motivation, observable religious seriousness, compatibility with speech-act insight.

Objections: believers intend to assert God's reality; secular agape is possible; religious utterances have many functions; similar policies cannot adjudicate incompatible theologies. The "atheist's account" criticism targets intentional misdescription, not moral value.

A mixed speech-act reply preserves his insight: the statement can assert divine love and commit agape together.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: moral commitment is a genuine dimension. **Evidence:** Braithwaite's agapeistic policy and stories. **Analysis:** the account explains practice. **Qualification:** it cannot replace the utterance's intended reference or cover all religious speech.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not equate Braithwaite with Ayer.
- Do not call stories merely false decorations; they sustain policy in his account.
- Do not criticise before reconstructing the practical gain.

MINI RECAP

Useful pragmatics; inadequate total semantics.

SESSION 14 - WITTGENSTEINIAN GRAMMAR AND THE PHILLIPS CAUTION

DEFINITION

Wittgenstein's lectures and later Wittgensteinian approaches analyse religious meaning through use, grammar, language-games and forms of life rather than isolated empirical resemblance.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Meaning-in-use prevents category mistakes, but it does not automatically prove non-cognitivism or immunise a practice from criticism.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Wittgenstein
- Last Judgement
- language-game
- grammar
- form of life
- D. Z. Phillips

VISUAL - WITTGENSTEINIAN GRAMMAR AND THE PHILLIPS CAUTION

LAST JUDGEMENT BELIEF

not simply -> tomorrow's weather prediction

functions in -> repentance · hope · fear · orientation

|
later grammar / form-of-life analysis

|
CAUTION: use != automatic non-cognition

PHILLIPS resisted reductionist label

The Last Judgement example shows that disagreement may involve an entire picture of life rather than one forecast. Prayer, confession and blessing gain meaning through their grammatical place.

Later Wittgensteinians differ. D. Z. Phillips argued that describing religious grammar does not reduce faith to attitude or fiction. The straightforward "Wittgenstein = non-cognitivist" formula is therefore unsafe.

The standard objection is fideism: if only insiders' grammar matters, external evidence and moral criticism seem excluded. Reply: language-games overlap, actions have public consequences, and clarification does not itself confer truth.

Mitchell's model helps preserve both internal commitment and external counterevidence.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: use is constitutive of intelligibility. **Evidence:** Last Judgement as life-orienting rather than a dated forecast.

Analysis: decontextualised scientific testing misclassifies the utterance. **Qualification:** grammar cannot settle truth or moral acceptability by itself.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not attribute every language-game thesis directly to a systematic Wittgenstein doctrine.
- Do not label Phillips non-cognitivist without qualification.
- Do not let form of life become an immunity shield.

MINI RECAP

Context explains meaning; it does not automatically vindicate belief.

SESSION 15 - ADVAITA I: BRAHMAN'S INEFFABILITY AND MĀYĀ'S INDETERMINABILITY

DEFINITION

Advaita distinguishes Brahman's non-objectifiability from the technical indeterminability (*anirvacanīyatā*) of māyā/world-appearance.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Brahman is ineffable but real; māyā is indeterminable because it cannot be classified as either absolutely real or unreal.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Brahman
- avācya
- anirvacanīya
- māyā
- sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa
- sublation

VISUAL - ADVAITA I: BRAHMAN'S INEFFABILITY AND MĀYĀ'S INDETERMINABILITY

BRAHMAN

SAT · non-objectifiable · words turn back
NOT "neither real nor unreal"

MĀYĀ / WORLD-APPEARANCE

appears -> not sheer unreality
sublated -> not ultimate reality
therefore SAD-ASAD-VILAKṢAṆA
-> technically ANIRVACANĪYA

The 2025 PYQ requires exact control. World-appearance functions transactionally, so it is not a hare's horn; knowledge sublates it, so it is not ultimately real. Binary predication fails.

Brahman presents a different limit. It is not an object under predicates, but it is *sat*. The Taittirīya formula "whence words turn back" marks objectifying speech's failure.

Calling both "indescribable" without distinction destroys the doctrine. The technical term *anirvacanīya* belongs to māyā's category status; Brahman's problem is non-objectifiability.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: two linguistic limits are distinct. **Evidence:** appearance plus sublation yields sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa for māyā.

Analysis: classificatory predication fails. **Qualification:** Brahman remains real and is not assigned māyā's ontological status.

UPSC TRAPS

- Never say Brahman is neither real nor unreal.
- Never translate anirvacanīya as vague ignorance alone.
- Do not omit sublation from the explanation.

MINI RECAP

Māyā defeats classification; Brahman defeats objectification.

SESSION 16 - ADVAITA II AND BOUNDED INDIAN SEMANTIC STRATEGIES

DEFINITION

Advaita uses eliminative negation and indirect indication; other Indian schools supply different bounded strategies that must not be collapsed.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Indian comparison adds marks only when the semantic mechanism and doctrinal boundary are both stated.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- *neti neti*
- *lakṣaṇā*
- *bhāga-tyāga*
- *vidhi*
- *śabda-nityatva*
- *syādvāda*

VISUAL - ADVAITA II AND BOUNDED INDIAN SEMANTIC STRATEGIES

ADVAITA -> neti neti removes limits
-> lakṣaṇā indicates indirectly
-> bhāga-tyāga in tat tvam asi
RĀMĀNUJA -> real auspicious predicates
MADHYAMAKA -> conventional discourse / no intrinsic nature
JAIN -> syāt marks the respect of assertion
MĪMĀṂSĀ -> vidhi + mantra + śabda-nityatva
GRAMMARIANS -> sphoṭa, especially Bhartṛhari

Advaita. *Neti neti* (Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6) removes limiting identifications. Indirect indication (*lakṣaṇā*) operates when literal sense fails. In "That thou art" (*tat tvam asi*), part-discarding indication (*bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā*) discards incompatible omniscient/finite connotations and retains consciousness.

Other bounded comparisons. Rāmānuja affirms real auspicious attributes; Madhyamaka permits conventional meaning without intrinsic essence; Jain conditional predication (*syādvāda*) states the standpoint; Mīmāṃsā gives injunction (*vidhi*) priority in disclosing *dharma* and treats mantra instrumentally.

Nyāya may be placed near the univocity pole only as a **limited comparative heuristic**, because it predicates knowledge, will and agency determinately of God (Īśvara). This is not a Nyāya doctrine equivalent to Scotus's semantic univocity or intrinsic modes.

School boundary: eternity of word/sound (*śabda-nityatva*) is Mīmāṃsā; classical sentence-whole disclosure (*sphoṭa*) belongs principally to grammarians, especially Bhartṛhari.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: religious language can function eliminatively and indicatively. **Evidence:** neti neti and bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā.

Analysis: false literal connotations are removed while intended import remains. **Qualification:** this structural analogy does not make Advaita identical to Aquinas or other schools.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not attribute sphoṭa to Mīmāṃsā.
- Do not make every scriptural sentence grammatically imperative.
- Do not convert bounded comparison into doctrinal identity.

MINI RECAP

Exact mechanism plus exact boundary: that is useful comparison.

SESSION 17 - HOW SYMBOLISM CAN LEAD TO MYSTICISM

DEFINITION

Symbolism can lead to mysticism through participation, interiorisation, transparency and self-effacement, culminating in claimed immediacy beyond the bearer.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The "how" is a sequence: symbol participates, draws the practitioner in, becomes transparent and is finally transcended.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- participation
- Ricoeur
- cataphatic/apophatic
- pratīka upāsana
- omkāra
- turīya

VISUAL - HOW SYMBOLISM CAN LEAD TO MYSTICISM

SYMBOL PARTICIPATES

v

PRACTICE / CONTEMPLATION draws subject in

v

TRANSPARENCY -> pointer becomes window

v

SELF-EFFACEMENT -> bearer falls away

v

CLAIMED IMMEDIACY / MYSTICISM

OM: A-U-M -> waking/dream/deep sleep -> AMĀTRA / TURĪYA

Tillich supplies participation. Ricoeur's "symbol gives rise to thought" and second naïvete explain interpretive deepening. Pseudo-Dionysius moves from affirmative naming to negative stripping and silence.

Indian traditions give graded examples. Symbol/image meditation (*pratīka/pratimā upāsanā*) can prepare the move from qualified to unqualified realisation. The *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* maps *Om*'s three measures to waking, dream and deep sleep; the soundless fourth points beyond the articulated symbol.

Eliade's **hierophany** adds the spatial mechanism: the sacred is encountered through a finite place or object without being exhausted by it. Tantric mantra, diagram (*yantra*) and sacred diagram (*maṇḍala*) can be internalised and dissolved; Sufi allusive signs (*ishārāt*) similarly point beyond literal expression. The mechanism is pedagogical and experiential, not logical entailment.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: symbols can function as self-transcending instruments. **Evidence:** omkāra to soundless turīya and cataphatic to apophatic ascent. **Analysis:** structured practice shifts attention from bearer to referent. **Qualification:** biography and tradition do not prove veridicality or necessity.

UPSC TRAPS

- Answer both WHETHER and HOW.
- Do not say every symbol necessarily causes mysticism.
- Do not omit the self-effacing stage.

MINI RECAP

Participation can become transparency, then silence.

SESSION 18 - WHY SYMBOLISM MAY NOT LEAD TO MYSTICISM

DEFINITION

Symbols may arrest in literalism, constitute rather than precede experience, or be unnecessary where iconoclasm, inquiry, ethics or grace provide alternative routes.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A top answer pairs the affirmative route with idolatry, constructivism, iconoclasm and non-necessity.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- idolatry
- demonic
- Steven Katz
- constructivism
- iconoclasm
- non-necessity

VISUAL - WHY SYMBOLISM MAY NOT LEAD TO MYSTICISM

FOUR COUNTER-ROUTES

- 1 ARREST -> finite bearer claims ultimacy
- 2 CONSTITUTE -> Katz: experience is symbol-shaped from start
- 3 DELETE -> Zen / *neti neti* iconoclasm
- 4 BYPASS -> ethics / inquiry / grace

RESULT -> normal route != necessary route != guarantee

Tillich's own idolatry warning is the first counterexample: a symbol can conceal by claiming ultimacy. Constructivism goes deeper. Steven Katz argues that inherited categories shape mystical experience, so there may be no symbol-free terminus.

Some disciplines advance by subtraction: Zen iconoclasm and *neti neti* do not deepen a positive image. Other routes-ethical purification, inquiry (*manana*), contemplative attention and grace-show non-necessity.

Mystics also return to symbols to communicate. The relation may be circular rather than a simple ladder: symbol shapes experience, experience reinterprets symbol.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: symbolism is not sufficient or necessary. **Evidence:** Tillich's demonic, Katz and iconoclastic routes. **Analysis:** each blocks a different premise of inevitability. **Qualification:** the negative case does not deny that disciplined symbols often function effectively.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not use Katz as proof that mysticism is false.
- Do not treat iconoclasm as absence of all learned practice.
- Do not conclude "never" from "not necessary".

MINI RECAP

Normal and powerful; neither necessary nor guaranteed.

SESSION 19 - THE PLURALISM BRIDGE: SEMANTICS BEFORE RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY

DEFINITION

A theory of religious language determines whether rival traditions' claims are flat contradictions, partial mode-relative descriptions or distinct practices.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

How one speaks about God determines how many traditions one can regard as speaking about God.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- semantic bridge
- transcategorical Real
- *personae/impersonae*
- *nirguṇa/saguṇa*
- *syādvāda*
- hard contradiction

VISUAL - THE PLURALISM BRIDGE: SEMANTICS BEFORE RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY

SEMANTICS -> EPISTEMIC ACCESS -> RIVAL DESCRIPTIONS -> PLURALISM

UNIVOCAL LITERALISM -> direct commensurability -> contradiction/exclusivism

ANALOGY / SYMBOL / APOPHASIS -> non-exhaustive modes -> pluralism possible

LIMIT: creator/no-creator and survival/no-survival remain hard existence claims

Hick's pluralism is a religious-language thesis. The Real *an sich* is transcategorical; personal and non-personal **personae/impersonae** are phenomenal forms. Remove the predication limit and the pluralist hypothesis collapses.

The same limit generates the vacuity objection: a Real of which nothing substantial can be said may be indistinguishable from nothing.

Advaita supplies two-level semantics: the unqualified (*nirguṇa*) exceeds exhaustive predication while qualified (*saguṇa*) forms structure devotion. Jain conditional predication specifies the standpoint inside the proposition and is more disciplined than mere unknowability.

Non-literal semantics resolves some apparent conflicts and not hard existence-claims. Route contradictions; do not harmonise them rhetorically.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: pluralism depends on semantic non-exhaustiveness. **Evidence:** Hick's transcategorical Real and Advaita's two levels. **Analysis:** rival descriptions need not compete in the same mode. **Qualification:** creator/no-creator cannot both be true in the same respect.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not claim analogy proves pluralism.
- Do not hide Hick's vacuity problem.
- Do not dissolve hard contradictions through rhetoric.

MINI RECAP

Semantics makes pluralism intelligible, not automatically true.

SESSION 20 - SYNTHESIS: DEBATES, DIRECTIVES, TRAPS AND ANSWER SPINE

DEFINITION

A complete answer locates the question on HOW and/or WHETHER, reconstructs the mechanism, tests the strongest objection and gives a graded verdict.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The defensible synthesis is qualified mixed realism: intelligible reference, non-literal mode, practical force and critical vulnerability.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- directive fidelity
- inter-thinker grid
- graded verdict
- quotation discipline
- claim-evidence-analysis-qualification
- mixed realism

VISUAL - SYNTHESIS: DEBATES, DIRECTIVES, TRAPS AND ANSWER SPINE

QUESTION

- > WHICH AXIS? HOW / WHETHER / BOTH
- > DEFINE MECHANISM
- > NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE
- > WHAT IT PROVES
- > STRONGEST OBJECTION
- > REPLY + RESIDUAL COST
- > GRADED VERDICT

10m: one mechanism + objection

15m: comparison + reply

20m: spectrum + two objections + defended synthesis

Thinker/theory	Gain	Standing cost
Aquinas	realism without crude anthropomorphism	indeterminacy
Scotus	valid inference	anthropomorphism/onto-theology charge
Maimonides	transcendence	vacuity
Tillich	participatory depth	vague referent/self-reference
Ayer/Flew	evidential discipline	over-restriction
Braithwaite	moral seriousness	reductionism
Wittgensteinian use	contextual meaning	insulation risk
Advaita	non-objectifying indication	self-reference/silence

Directive decoder. "In what sense" demands axes; "whether and how" demands a route plus negative case; "with reference to" requires thinker fidelity; the 2024 10+10 question requires two visibly balanced parts.

Quotation discipline. Keep Aquinas's res/modus pair; Scotus semantic not ontological; Tillich's exception disputed; Phillips qualification; Brahman versus māyā; Mīmāṃsā versus grammarian *sphoṭa*.

Final formula: univocity buys inference and risks anthropomorphism; analogy buys transcendence and risks indeterminacy; negation buys purity and risks vacuity. Mixed realism preserves assertion while admitting symbol, performance and fallibility.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: no single family explains the whole field. **Evidence:** Aquinas, Tillich, Evans and Mitchell solve different problems. **Analysis:** mode, force and warrant are independent dimensions. **Qualification:** "mixed" must still specify referent, evidence and limits.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do not write a thinker list without mechanism.
- Do not merge analogy, symbol and non-cognitivism.
- Do not omit contested attribution controls.

MINI RECAP

Axis -> mechanism -> evidence -> objection -> qualified verdict.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24

MCQ 1. Which formulation best distinguishes the two main axes in the study of religious language?

A. HOW asks whether God exists; WHETHER asks which religion is oldest, in every context. B. HOW concerns only ritual; WHETHER concerns only mysticism, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. C. HOW is cognitive; WHETHER is necessarily non-cognitive, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. HOW asks how transcendent predicates signify; WHETHER asks whether utterances are truth-apt.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "HOW asks whether God exists; WHETHER asks which religion is oldest, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. Univocity, equivocity, analogy, symbol, negation and *lakṣaṇā* answer the semantic HOW question. Cognitivism, moral-conative theories, *bliks*, meaning-as-use and verificationism address WHETHER religious utterances state truths. A theory may cross the axes: Tillich can offer symbolic mode while retaining symbolic realism; a performative may carry assertoric presuppositions.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "HOW concerns only ritual; WHETHER concerns only mysticism, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. Univocity, equivocity, analogy, symbol, negation and *lakṣaṇā* answer the semantic HOW question. Cognitivism, moral-conative theories, *bliks*, meaning-as-use and verificationism address WHETHER religious utterances state truths. A theory may cross the axes: Tillich can offer symbolic mode while retaining symbolic realism; a performative may carry assertoric presuppositions.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "HOW is cognitive; WHETHER is necessarily non-cognitive, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Univocity, equivocity, analogy, symbol, negation and *lakṣaṇā* answer the semantic HOW question. Cognitivism, moral-conative theories, *bliks*, meaning-as-use and verificationism address WHETHER religious utterances state truths. A theory may cross the axes: Tillich can offer symbolic mode while retaining symbolic realism; a performative may carry assertoric presuppositions.
- **D:** Correct: Univocity, equivocity, analogy, symbol, negation and *lakṣaṇā* answer the semantic HOW question. Cognitivism, moral-conative theories, *bliks*, meaning-as-use and verificationism address WHETHER religious utterances state truths. A theory may cross the axes: Tillich can offer symbolic mode while retaining symbolic realism; a performative may carry assertoric presuppositions.

Examiner trap 1: Separate HOW from WHETHER; symbolic mode does not settle truth-aptness.

MCQ 2. Aquinas' analogy of proportionality most nearly means that:

A. goodness belongs to God according to the divine mode as it belongs to creatures according to theirs. B. "Good" has wholly unrelated meanings for God and creatures, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. C. divine goodness is only a metaphor generated by human emotion, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. God is called good only because believers choose a moral policy, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Proportionality compares relations across distinct modes of being; it neither asserts univocal sameness nor equivocal disconnection. Attribution instead orders secondary uses to a primary source. The metaphysical ground is causal participation: an effect resembles its cause without possessing perfection in the same finite manner.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "'Good' has wholly unrelated meanings for God and creatures, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. Proportionality compares relations across distinct modes of being; it neither asserts univocal sameness nor equivocal disconnection. Attribution instead orders secondary uses to a primary source. The metaphysical ground is causal participation: an effect resembles its cause without possessing perfection in the same finite manner.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "divine goodness is only a metaphor generated by human emotion, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Proportionality compares relations across distinct modes of being; it neither asserts univocal sameness nor

equivocal disconnection. Attribution instead orders secondary uses to a primary source. The metaphysical ground is causal participation: an effect resembles its cause without possessing perfection in the same finite manner.

- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "God is called good only because believers choose a moral policy, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Proportionality compares relations across distinct modes of being; it neither asserts univocal sameness nor equivocal disconnection. Attribution instead orders secondary uses to a primary source. The metaphysical ground is causal participation: an effect resembles its cause without possessing perfection in the same finite manner.

Examiner trap 2: Attribution/proportionality is later Thomist, especially Cajetanian, systematisation.

MCQ 3. In Aquinas' account, what is the function of the distinction between *res significata* and *modus significandi*?

A. It converts every divine predicate into a liturgical command, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. B. It makes God and creatures ontologically members of one genus, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. C. It permits the perfection signified to apply truly while treating the creaturely manner of signifying as inadequate. D. It denies that perfection-terms signify anything of God, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "It converts every divine predicate into a liturgical command, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. The *res significata*-for example goodness-can be affirmed of God, while the *modus significandi* reflects finite creaturely cognition and therefore cannot capture God's mode of possession. This technical pair is how Aquinas protects realism without crude anthropomorphism.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "It makes God and creatures ontologically members of one genus, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. The *res significata*-for example goodness-can be affirmed of God, while the *modus significandi* reflects finite creaturely cognition and therefore cannot capture God's mode of possession. This technical pair is how Aquinas protects realism without crude anthropomorphism.
- **C:** Correct: The *res significata*-for example goodness-can be affirmed of God, while the *modus significandi* reflects finite creaturely cognition and therefore cannot capture God's mode of possession. This technical pair is how Aquinas protects realism without crude anthropomorphism.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "It denies that perfection-terms signify anything of God, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. The *res significata*-for example goodness-can be affirmed of God, while the *modus significandi* reflects finite creaturely cognition and therefore cannot capture God's mode of possession. This technical pair is how Aquinas protects realism without crude anthropomorphism.

Examiner trap 3: Do not reduce Aquinas to cause-only language; *res significata* applies essentially and eminently.

MCQ 4. Maimonides permits which form of discourse about God most characteristically?

A. Only univocal positive predicates shared with creatures, in every context. B. Purely fictional stories with no theological intent, under the theory's own terms. C. Symbols understood as identical with their divine referent, for every form of religious discourse. D. Negations and attributes of action rather than positive essential attributes, while preserving its other speech functions.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Only univocal positive predicates shared with creatures, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. In *Guide for the Perplexed* I.50-60, Maimonides protects divine simplicity and transcendence: one may deny ignorance or describe God as merciful from divine action, without positing a creature-like essential quality. The standard objection is vacuity-unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Purely fictional stories with no theological intent, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. In *Guide for the Perplexed* I.50-60, Maimonides protects divine simplicity and transcendence: one may deny ignorance or describe God as merciful from divine action, without positing a creature-like essential quality. The standard objection is vacuity-unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Symbols understood as identical with their divine referent, for every form of religious discourse.". It fails the controlling distinction. In *Guide for the Perplexed* I.50-60, Maimonides protects divine simplicity and transcendence: one may deny ignorance or describe God as merciful from divine action, without positing a creature-like essential quality. The standard objection is vacuity-unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.
- **D:** Correct: In *Guide for the Perplexed* I.50-60, Maimonides protects divine simplicity and transcendence: one may deny ignorance or describe God as merciful from divine action, without positing a creature-like essential quality. The standard objection is vacuity-unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.

Examiner trap 4: Maimonides permits negations and attributes of action, not creaturely positive essence.

MCQ 5. What most decisively distinguishes a Tillichian symbol from a sign?

A. A symbol is always linguistic whereas a sign is always visual, in every context. B. A symbol participates in what it indicates and opens levels of reality and self, under the stated distinction. C. A symbol has one fixed conventional meaning and cannot die, for every form of religious discourse. D. A symbol is merely an inaccurate literal statement, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "A symbol is always linguistic whereas a sign is always visual, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol participates, discloses, transforms, arises collectively and may grow or die. Calling symbol a mere sign destroys Tillich's mechanism. Symbolic language is non-literal, but it need not be non-cognitive or arbitrary.
- **B:** Correct: A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol participates, discloses, transforms, arises collectively and may grow or die. Calling symbol a mere sign destroys Tillich's mechanism. Symbolic language is non-literal, but it need not be non-cognitive or arbitrary.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "A symbol has one fixed conventional meaning and cannot die, for every form of religious discourse.". It fails the controlling distinction. A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol participates, discloses, transforms, arises collectively and may grow or die. Calling symbol a mere sign destroys Tillich's mechanism. Symbolic language is non-literal, but it need not be non-cognitive or arbitrary.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "A symbol is merely an inaccurate literal statement, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol participates, discloses, transforms, arises collectively and may grow or die. Calling symbol a mere sign destroys Tillich's mechanism. Symbolic language is non-literal, but it need not be non-cognitive or arbitrary.

Examiner trap 5: Tillichian symbol participates and discloses; a conventional pointer is only a sign.

MCQ 6. Ian Ramsey's "model and qualifier" account explains religious language by claiming that:

A. an ordinary model is stretched by a qualifier until a disclosure situation occurs, while preserving its other speech functions. B. religious models are univocal scientific descriptions, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. C. models are dispensable once a creed is memorised, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. D. qualifiers cancel all ordinary content, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: "Father," "cause" or "good" supplies a model; "heavenly," "first" or "infinitely" qualifies and develops it until the "penny drops." Ramsey explains continuity with ordinary speech without reducing religious use either to literal identity or complete equivocation.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "religious models are univocal scientific descriptions, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. "Father," "cause" or "good" supplies a model; "heavenly," "first" or "infinitely" qualifies and develops it until the "penny drops." Ramsey explains continuity with ordinary speech without reducing religious use either to literal identity or complete equivocation.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "models are dispensable once a creed is memorised, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. "Father," "cause" or "good" supplies a model; "heavenly," "first" or "infinitely" qualifies and develops it until the "penny drops." Ramsey explains continuity with ordinary speech without reducing religious use either to literal identity or complete equivocation.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "qualifiers cancel all ordinary content, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. "Father," "cause" or "good" supplies a model; "heavenly," "first" or "infinitely" qualifies and develops it until the "penny drops." Ramsey explains continuity with ordinary speech without reducing religious use either to literal identity or complete equivocation.

Examiner trap 6: Ramsey stretches an ordinary model by a qualifier; he does not cancel ordinary meaning.

MCQ 7. Which religious utterance most clearly illustrates Austin's performative analysis?

A. "The temple was built of stone," used as an archaeological report, without qualification. B. "I take refuge in the Buddha," sincerely uttered as an act of commitment, with qualification. C. "Some believers fast," used as a sociological description, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice. D. "The manuscript contains five chapters," used bibliographically, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states ""The temple was built of stone," used as an archaeological report, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. The utterance does not merely report a prior state; under appropriate conditions it performs the act of taking refuge. Austin's constative/performative and illocutionary analysis shows why testing every religious sentence as a detached description is a category mistake.
- **B:** Correct: The utterance does not merely report a prior state; under appropriate conditions it performs the act of taking refuge. Austin's constative/performative and illocutionary analysis shows why testing every religious sentence as a detached description is a category mistake.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states ""Some believers fast," used as a sociological description, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.". It fails the controlling distinction. The utterance does not merely report a prior state; under appropriate conditions it performs the act of taking refuge. Austin's constative/performative and illocutionary analysis shows why testing every religious sentence as a detached description is a category mistake.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states ""The manuscript contains five chapters," used bibliographically, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. The utterance does not merely report a prior state; under appropriate conditions it performs the act of taking refuge. Austin's constative/performative and illocutionary analysis shows why testing every religious sentence as a

detached description is a category mistake.

Examiner trap 7: A performative enacts a relation under felicity conditions; it is not merely unverifiable.

MCQ 8. Donald Evans' idea of self-involvement is best captured by which claim?

A. Religious utterances are always private sensations, under the theory's own terms. B. Self-involvement proves that religious statements cannot assert anything, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. C. Their avowal characteristically implicates the speaker in attitudes, relationships and conduct, with qualification. D. Only first-person sentences have religious meaning, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Religious utterances are always private sensations, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. Evans extends speech-act analysis to religion: confession, vow and commitment constitute relations and practical stances. Self-involvement does not by itself eliminate cognitive content; a performative can presuppose assertions and a sentence can be assertoric and commissive together.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Self-involvement proves that religious statements cannot assert anything, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Evans extends speech-act analysis to religion: confession, vow and commitment constitute relations and practical stances. Self-involvement does not by itself eliminate cognitive content; a performative can presuppose assertions and a sentence can be assertoric and commissive together.
- **C:** Correct: Evans extends speech-act analysis to religion: confession, vow and commitment constitute relations and practical stances. Self-involvement does not by itself eliminate cognitive content; a performative can presuppose assertions and a sentence can be assertoric and commissive together.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Only first-person sentences have religious meaning, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Evans extends speech-act analysis to religion: confession, vow and commitment constitute relations and practical stances. Self-involvement does not by itself eliminate cognitive content; a performative can presuppose assertions and a sentence can be assertoric and commissive together.

Examiner trap 8: Self-involvement concerns commitment, not privacy or automatic non-cognitivism.

MCQ 9. A. J. Ayer's challenge to "God exists" rests primarily on the claim that:

A. it is false because evil exists, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice. B. it is neither analytically true nor empirically verifiable and is therefore literally meaningless. C. it expresses a morally admirable *blik*, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. it is analogical rather than univocal, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "it is false because evil exists, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ayer's is hostile non-cognitivism, unlike Braithwaite's constructive moral account. Critics argue that the verification criterion is too narrow and faces a self-application problem, since the criterion itself is not straightforwardly analytic or empirically verified.
- **B:** Correct: Ayer's is hostile non-cognitivism, unlike Braithwaite's constructive moral account. Critics argue that the verification criterion is too narrow and faces a self-application problem, since the criterion itself is not straightforwardly analytic or empirically verified.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "it expresses a morally admirable *blik*, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ayer's is hostile non-cognitivism, unlike Braithwaite's constructive moral account. Critics argue that the verification criterion is too narrow and faces a self-application problem, since the criterion itself is not straightforwardly analytic or empirically verified.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "it is analogical rather than univocal, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ayer's is

hostile non-cognitivism, unlike Braithwaite's constructive moral account. Critics argue that the verification criterion is too narrow and faces a self-application problem, since the criterion itself is not straightforwardly analytic or empirically verified.

Examiner trap 9: Ayer calls God-talk meaningless by his criterion; he does not merely call it false.

MCQ 10. Flew's invisible-gardener parable is designed to ask:

A. what conceivable evidence could count against a religious assertion before qualifications empty it of content, with qualification. B. whether God can be named only negatively, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. C. whether religious stories improve moral motivation, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification. D. whether symbols arise from collective life, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Flew, adapting John Wisdom, argues that a claim can "die the death of a thousand qualifications" if every counter-instance is absorbed. The target is evidential immunity and loss of falsifiable content, not symbolism or moral function.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "whether God can be named only negatively, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. Flew, adapting John Wisdom, argues that a claim can "die the death of a thousand qualifications" if every counter-instance is absorbed. The target is evidential immunity and loss of falsifiable content, not symbolism or moral function.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "whether religious stories improve moral motivation, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Flew, adapting John Wisdom, argues that a claim can "die the death of a thousand qualifications" if every counter-instance is absorbed. The target is evidential immunity and loss of falsifiable content, not symbolism or moral function.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "whether symbols arise from collective life, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. Flew, adapting John Wisdom, argues that a claim can "die the death of a thousand qualifications" if every counter-instance is absorbed. The target is evidential immunity and loss of falsifiable content, not symbolism or moral function.

Examiner trap 10: Flew asks what counts against the assertion; do not confuse falsification with verification.

MCQ 11. R. M. Hare's response to Flew uses bliks to describe:

A. empirically verified predictions about divine action, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. B. analogies grounded in causal participation, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. C. basic, unfalsifiable ways of seeing the world that can still govern life significantly, under the stated distinction. D. liturgical commands unique to Mīmāṃsā, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "empirically verified predictions about divine action, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hare's paranoid student illustrates that a *blik* may resist evidence yet profoundly shape conduct. Hare thereby rejects Flew's inference from unfalsifiability to unimportance, but at the cost of giving up ordinary factual assertion.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "analogies grounded in causal participation, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hare's paranoid student illustrates that a *blik* may resist evidence yet profoundly shape conduct. Hare thereby rejects Flew's inference from unfalsifiability to unimportance, but at the cost of giving up ordinary factual assertion.
- **C:** Correct: Hare's paranoid student illustrates that a *blik* may resist evidence yet profoundly shape conduct. Hare thereby rejects Flew's inference from unfalsifiability to unimportance, but at the cost of giving up ordinary factual assertion.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "liturgical commands unique to Mīmāṃsā, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hare's paranoid student illustrates that a *blik* may resist evidence yet profoundly shape conduct. Hare thereby rejects Flew's inference from unfalsifiability to unimportance, but at the cost of giving up ordinary factual assertion.

Examiner trap 11: Hare preserves practical importance through a blik but gives up ordinary factual vulnerability.

MCQ 12. Hick's eschatological verification claims that a religious proposition may be:

A. falsifiable now but never verifiable, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. B. truth-apt now and confirmable at the eschaton, despite lacking present decisive verification, under the stated distinction. C. meaningless now but meaningful after death, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. D. only a symbol with no possible confirmation, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "falsifiable now but never verifiable, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hick's celestial-city parable distinguishes present testability from verification in principle. Travellers may differ about their destination while the journey's end could settle the issue asymmetrically. The account answers Ayer but raises questions about present warrant and falsifiability.
- **B:** Correct: Hick's celestial-city parable distinguishes present testability from verification in principle. Travellers may differ about their destination while the journey's end could settle the issue asymmetrically. The account answers Ayer but raises questions about present warrant and falsifiability.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "meaningless now but meaningful after death, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hick's celestial-city parable distinguishes present testability from verification in principle. Travellers may differ about their destination while the journey's end could settle the issue asymmetrically. The account answers Ayer but raises questions about present warrant and falsifiability.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "only a symbol with no possible confirmation, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Hick's celestial-city parable distinguishes present testability from verification in principle. Travellers may differ about their destination while the journey's end could settle the issue asymmetrically. The account answers Ayer but raises questions about present warrant and falsifiability.

Examiner trap 12: Hick claims truth-aptness now with possible future confirmation; verification is asymmetrical.

MCQ 13. According to Braithwaite, "God is love" primarily functions as:

A. a declaration of commitment to an agapeistic moral policy sustained by religious stories. B. an analogy of attribution, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. C. a prediction verified at the end of history, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice. D. a literal report of an observable divine property, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Braithwaite preserves religion's practical seriousness while relinquishing metaphysical fact-reporting as primary meaning. His account differs from Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's world-picture and Wittgensteinian grammar. Its central weakness is reductionism: believers generally intend reference as well as commitment.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "an analogy of attribution, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Braithwaite preserves religion's practical seriousness while relinquishing metaphysical fact-reporting as primary meaning. His account differs from Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's world-picture and Wittgensteinian grammar. Its central weakness is reductionism: believers generally intend reference as well as commitment.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "a prediction verified at the end of history, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.". It fails the controlling distinction. Braithwaite preserves religion's practical seriousness while relinquishing metaphysical fact-reporting as primary meaning. His account differs from Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's world-picture and Wittgensteinian grammar. Its central weakness is reductionism: believers generally intend reference as well as commitment.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "a literal report of an observable divine property, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Braithwaite preserves religion's practical seriousness while relinquishing metaphysical fact-reporting as primary meaning. His account differs from Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's world-picture and Wittgensteinian grammar. Its central weakness is reductionism: believers generally intend reference as well as commitment.

Examiner trap 13: Braithwaite is constructive moral-conative non-cognitivism, not Ayerian elimination.

MCQ 14. Which statement best reflects the Wittgensteinian approach to religious language?

A. Every religious claim is meaningless by verificationist criteria, for every form of religious discourse. B. Every religious sentence expresses the same agapeistic policy, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. C. Religious grammar is identical to laboratory reporting, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. Meaning should be sought in use within a religious language-game and form of life, while preserving its other speech functions.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Every religious claim is meaningless by verificationist criteria, for every form of religious discourse.". It fails the controlling distinction. Prayer, confession or belief in Last Judgement is understood through its role in worship, repentance and orientation. The approach resists decontextualised scientific testing. It can be criticised for fideistic insulation, but it is not equivalent to Ayer or Braithwaite.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Every religious sentence expresses the same agapeistic policy, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. Prayer, confession or belief in Last Judgement is understood through its role in worship, repentance and orientation. The approach resists decontextualised scientific testing. It can be criticised for fideistic insulation, but it is not equivalent to Ayer or Braithwaite.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Religious grammar is identical to laboratory reporting, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. Prayer, confession or belief in Last Judgement is understood through its role in worship, repentance and orientation. The approach resists decontextualised scientific testing. It can be criticised for fideistic insulation, but it is not equivalent to Ayer or Braithwaite.

- **D:** Correct: Prayer, confession or belief in Last Judgement is understood through its role in worship, repentance and orientation. The approach resists decontextualised scientific testing. It can be criticised for fideistic insulation, but it is not equivalent to Ayer or Braithwaite.

Examiner trap 14: Wittgensteinian use clarifies grammar; it does not automatically deny truth.

MCQ 15. What qualification is required when discussing D. Z. Phillips?

A. He created Ayer's verification principle, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. B. He defended Scotus' intrinsic modes, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification. C. He rejected being labelled a non-cognitivist or reductionist and presented his work as clarification of religious grammar, under the stated distinction. D. He reduced all worship to fictionalism, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "He created Ayer's verification principle, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Phillips is associated with Wittgensteinian philosophy of religion, but reporting him simply as a non-cognitivist is factually unsafe. The interpretive dispute must be stated: attention to internal grammar does not automatically deny truth or reduce religion to attitude.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "He defended Scotus' intrinsic modes, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Phillips is associated with Wittgensteinian philosophy of religion, but reporting him simply as a non-cognitivist is factually unsafe. The interpretive dispute must be stated: attention to internal grammar does not automatically deny truth or reduce religion to attitude.
- **C:** Correct: Phillips is associated with Wittgensteinian philosophy of religion, but reporting him simply as a non-cognitivist is factually unsafe. The interpretive dispute must be stated: attention to internal grammar does not automatically deny truth or reduce religion to attitude.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "He reduced all worship to fictionalism, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. Phillips is associated with Wittgensteinian philosophy of religion, but reporting him simply as a non-cognitivist is factually unsafe. The interpretive dispute must be stated: attention to internal grammar does not automatically deny truth or reduce religion to attitude.

Examiner trap 15: Phillips rejected simple non-cognitivist/reductionist labels; report the dispute.

MCQ 16. Which analysis best describes a mixed speech-act account?

A. Assertions and performatives can never coexist, under the theory's own terms. B. Every religious utterance is only expressive, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. C. Cognitive content requires univocal literalism, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. D. Religious utterances may be assertoric, symbolic, expressive and commissive at once, while preserving its other speech functions.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Assertions and performatives can never coexist, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. "God exists" may assert reality, use analogical or symbolic reference, express trust and commit conduct. Mixed analysis avoids Braithwaite's reductionism without ignoring Austin and Evans. It also prevents the false inference that non-literal predication is necessarily non-cognitive.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Every religious utterance is only expressive, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. "God exists" may assert reality, use analogical or symbolic reference, express trust and commit conduct. Mixed analysis avoids Braithwaite's reductionism without ignoring Austin and Evans. It also prevents the false inference that non-literal predication is necessarily non-cognitive.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Cognitive content requires univocal literalism, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. "God exists" may assert reality, use analogical or symbolic reference, express trust and commit conduct. Mixed analysis avoids Braithwaite's reductionism without ignoring Austin and Evans. It also prevents the false inference that non-literal predication is necessarily non-cognitive.
- **D:** Correct: "God exists" may assert reality, use analogical or symbolic reference, express trust and commit conduct. Mixed analysis avoids Braithwaite's reductionism without ignoring Austin and Evans. It also prevents the false inference that non-literal predication is necessarily non-cognitive.

Examiner trap 16: Assertion, symbolism, expression and commitment can coexist in one utterance.

MCQ 17. Which comparison between secular and religious language is most defensible?

A. Secular language is always descriptive and religious language always performative, as the decisive criterion. B. They share ordinary words, but often differ in function, referent, verification, register and self-involvement, with qualification. C. They use completely different vocabularies, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification. D. Religious language violates all ordinary logic, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Secular language is always descriptive and religious language always performative, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. Religious language is a stretched, tradition-formed use of a common instrument, not a separate language. The comparison is one of typical functions rather than absolute boxes: secular speech also performs, while religious discourse can assert facts.
- **B:** Correct: Religious language is a stretched, tradition-formed use of a common instrument, not a separate language. The comparison is one of typical functions rather than absolute boxes: secular speech also performs, while religious discourse can assert facts.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "They use completely different vocabularies, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Religious language is a stretched, tradition-formed use of a common instrument, not a separate language. The comparison is one of typical functions rather than absolute boxes: secular speech also performs, while religious discourse can assert facts.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Religious language violates all ordinary logic, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Religious language is a stretched, tradition-formed use of a common instrument, not a separate language. The comparison is one of typical functions rather than absolute boxes: secular speech also performs, while religious discourse can assert facts.

Examiner trap 17: Secular and religious speech share vocabulary and overlap in function.

MCQ 18. In Advaita, *neti neti* primarily functions as:

A. a theory that *māyā* is absolutely unreal, as the decisive criterion. B. univocal description of Brahman's properties, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. C. the grammarian doctrine of a sentence-whole, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. eliminative negation of limiting identifications, not denial that Brahman is real, under the stated distinction.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "a theory that *māyā* is absolutely unreal, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. *Neti neti* marks the limit of objectifying predicates. It removes finite conceptions so that Brahman is not treated as an object among objects. The danger is apparent self-reference; Advaita replies that negating language is pedagogical and itself sublated.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "univocal description of Brahman's properties, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. *Neti neti* marks the limit of objectifying predicates. It removes finite conceptions so that Brahman is not treated as an object among objects. The danger is apparent self-reference; Advaita replies that negating language is pedagogical and itself sublated.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "the grammarian doctrine of a sentence-whole, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. *Neti neti* marks the limit of objectifying predicates. It removes finite conceptions so that Brahman is not treated as an object among objects. The danger is apparent self-reference; Advaita replies that negating language is pedagogical and itself sublated.
- **D:** Correct: *Neti neti* marks the limit of objectifying predicates. It removes finite conceptions so that Brahman is not treated as an object among objects. The danger is apparent self-reference; Advaita replies that negating language is pedagogical and itself sublated.

Examiner trap 18: *Neti neti* removes limiting predicates; it does not deny Brahman is real.

MCQ 19. What does *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* do in interpreting *tat tvam asi*?

A. It discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness as the common import. B. It retains every literal connotation of both terms, under the theory's own terms. C. It proves that *tat* and *tvam* are entirely equivocal, for every form of religious discourse. D. It classifies Brahman as neither real nor unreal, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Also called *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā*, this indirect indication sets aside omniscient causal and finite embodied standpoints while retaining their non-dual import. It is structurally comparable to analogy but belongs to Advaita's distinct pedagogical semantics.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "It retains every literal connotation of both terms, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. Also called *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā*, this indirect indication sets aside omniscient causal and finite embodied standpoints while retaining their non-dual import. It is structurally comparable to analogy but belongs to Advaita's distinct pedagogical semantics.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "It proves that *tat* and *tvam* are entirely equivocal, for every form of religious discourse.". It fails the controlling distinction. Also called *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā*, this indirect indication sets aside omniscient causal and finite embodied standpoints while retaining their non-dual import. It is structurally comparable to analogy but belongs to Advaita's distinct pedagogical semantics.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "It classifies Brahman as neither real nor unreal, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.". It fails the controlling distinction. Also called *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā*, this indirect indication sets aside omniscient causal and finite embodied standpoints while retaining their non-dual import. It is structurally comparable to analogy but belongs to Advaita's distinct pedagogical semantics.

Examiner trap 19: *Bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness.

MCQ 20. The Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad offers a model of symbol leading beyond itself because:

A. it treats sound as a literal material creator, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike. B. it denies any connection between *Om* and consciousness, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice. C. it identifies *turīya* with one more empirical state, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. A-U-M maps waking, dream and deep sleep, while soundless *amātra* indicates *turīya* beyond articulated sound, while preserving its other speech functions.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "it treats sound as a literal material creator, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike." It fails the controlling distinction. The articulated symbol structures contemplation and becomes self-transcending at the soundless fourth. It is the clearest Indian example of symbolism as graded mediation rather than a finite object demanding literal worship.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "it denies any connection between *Om* and consciousness, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice." It fails the controlling distinction. The articulated symbol structures contemplation and becomes self-transcending at the soundless fourth. It is the clearest Indian example of symbolism as graded mediation rather than a finite object demanding literal worship.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "it identifies *turīya* with one more empirical state, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation." It fails the controlling distinction. The articulated symbol structures contemplation and becomes self-transcending at the soundless fourth. It is the clearest Indian example of symbolism as graded mediation rather than a finite object demanding literal worship.
- **D:** Correct: The articulated symbol structures contemplation and becomes self-transcending at the soundless fourth. It is the clearest Indian example of symbolism as graded mediation rather than a finite object demanding literal worship.

Examiner trap 20: *Omkāra* is a graded symbol; it does not prove every symbol causes mysticism.

MCQ 21. Which statement best expresses the pluralism bridge in religious language?

A. Pluralism follows automatically from any belief in God, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice. B. Analogical, symbolic or apophatic semantics can make rival descriptions partial and mode-relative, though not all contradictions disappear, while preserving its other speech functions. C. Univocal literalism always proves all religions true, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. D. Non-cognitive language makes inter-religious disagreement impossible, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Pluralism follows automatically from any belief in God, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice." It fails the controlling distinction. Semantics shapes epistemic access and the status of rival claims. Non-literal approaches can soften personal/impersonal conflicts, but cannot dissolve hard existence-claims such as creator versus no creator or post-mortem survival versus extinction.
- **B:** Correct: Semantics shapes epistemic access and the status of rival claims. Non-literal approaches can soften personal/impersonal conflicts, but cannot dissolve hard existence-claims such as creator versus no creator or post-mortem survival versus extinction.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Univocal literalism always proves all religions true, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike." It fails the controlling distinction. Semantics shapes epistemic access and the status of rival claims. Non-literal approaches can soften personal/impersonal conflicts, but cannot dissolve hard existence-claims such as creator versus no creator or post-mortem survival versus extinction.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Non-cognitive language makes inter-religious disagreement impossible, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context." It fails the controlling distinction. Semantics shapes epistemic access and the status of rival claims. Non-literal approaches can soften personal/impersonal conflicts, but cannot dissolve hard existence-claims such as creator versus no

creator or post-mortem survival versus extinction.

Examiner trap 21: The pluralism bridge is semantic but cannot erase existence-contradictions.

MCQ 22. Which Indian resource most directly marks standpoint-relativity inside propositions rather than merely declaring the ultimate unknowable?

A. Grammarian *sphoṭa*, under the theory's own terms. B. Advaita *neti neti* alone, under the theory's own terms. C. Jain *anekāntavāda* expressed through *syādvāda* and *saptabhaṅgī*, under the stated distinction. D. Mīmāṃsā *vidhi*, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Grammarian *sphoṭa*, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. The prefix *syāt* locates assertions "in a certain respect," enabling apparently conflicting claims to be assigned to different *nayas*. This is more determinate than simply retreating to an unknowable referent.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Advaita *neti neti* alone, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. The prefix *syāt* locates assertions "in a certain respect," enabling apparently conflicting claims to be assigned to different *nayas*. This is more determinate than simply retreating to an unknowable referent.
- **C:** Correct: The prefix *syāt* locates assertions "in a certain respect," enabling apparently conflicting claims to be assigned to different *nayas*. This is more determinate than simply retreating to an unknowable referent.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Mīmāṃsā *vidhi*, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. The prefix *syāt* locates assertions "in a certain respect," enabling apparently conflicting claims to be assigned to different *nayas*. This is more determinate than simply retreating to an unknowable referent.

Examiner trap 22: Jain conditional predication states the respect; it does not license unconditional contradiction.

MCQ 23. With reference to Aquinas's divine predication, consider the following statements:

1. Pure perfections are present in God essentially and eminently.
2. The *modus significandi* derived from creatures adequately represents the divine mode.
3. "God is good" cannot be reduced to "God causes goodness."

Which of the statements given above are correct?

A. 1 and 3 only, while preserving its other speech functions. B. 1 and 2 only. C. 2 and 3 only, without qualification. D. 1, 2 and 3, as the decisive criterion.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: The perfection signified applies truly, but the creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate. Aquinas expressly rejects the cause-only paraphrase.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "1 and 2 only.". It fails the controlling distinction. The perfection signified applies truly, but the creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate. Aquinas expressly rejects the cause-only paraphrase.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "2 and 3 only, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. The perfection signified applies truly, but the creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate. Aquinas expressly rejects the cause-only paraphrase.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "1, 2 and 3, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. The perfection signified applies truly, but the creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate. Aquinas expressly rejects the cause-only paraphrase.

Examiner trap 23: Hold pure perfection and inadequate creaturely signification together.

MCQ 24. Match List I with List II:

List I	List II
1. Ramsey	a. Self-involving language
2. Evans	b. Model and qualifier
3. Mīmāṃsā	c. <i>Vidhi</i> priority in disclosing <i>dharma</i>
4. Bhartṛhari	d. Classical <i>sphoṭa</i>

A. 1-a, 2-b, 3-d, 4-c. B. 1-b, 2-c, 3-a, 4-d, without qualification. C. 1-b, 2-a, 3-c, 4-d, while preserving its other speech functions. D. 1-c, 2-a, 3-d, 4-b, as the decisive criterion.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "1-a, 2-b, 3-d, 4-c.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ramsey supplies model-and-qualifier, Evans self-involvement, Mīmāṃsā the priority of injunction for *dharma*, and the grammarian Bhartṛhari the classical *sphoṭa* account.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "1-b, 2-c, 3-a, 4-d, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ramsey supplies model-and-qualifier, Evans self-involvement, Mīmāṃsā the priority of injunction for *dharma*, and the grammarian Bhartṛhari the classical *sphoṭa* account.
- **C:** Correct: Ramsey supplies model-and-qualifier, Evans self-involvement, Mīmāṃsā the priority of injunction for *dharma*, and the grammarian Bhartṛhari the classical *sphoṭa* account.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "1-c, 2-a, 3-d, 4-b, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. Ramsey supplies model-and-qualifier, Evans self-involvement, Mīmāṃsā the priority of injunction for *dharma*, and the grammarian Bhartṛhari the classical *sphoṭa* account.

Examiner trap 24: Mīmāṃsā gives *vidhi* priority/śabda-nityatva; classical *sphoṭa* is principally Bhartṛhari.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8**MCQ 25. A student writes, "Tillich's symbol is merely a convenient sign for an absent object." What is the best correction?**

A. Tillich treats every sign as sacred, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. B. A Tillichian symbol participates in what it signifies and can disclose and transform; it is not merely conventional, with qualification. C. Tillich says symbols never die, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms. D. Tillich denies that symbols point beyond themselves, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Tillich treats every sign as sacred, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. The error removes Tillich's central mechanism. Participation, opening levels of reality/self, collective origin and mortality distinguish symbol from sign. A symbol still points beyond itself and must not absolutise its finite bearer.
- **B:** Correct: The error removes Tillich's central mechanism. Participation, opening levels of reality/self, collective origin and mortality distinguish symbol from sign. A symbol still points beyond itself and must not absolutise its finite bearer.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Tillich says symbols never die, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. The error removes Tillich's central mechanism. Participation, opening levels of reality/self, collective origin and mortality distinguish symbol from sign. A symbol still points beyond itself and must not absolutise its finite bearer.

- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Tillich denies that symbols point beyond themselves, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. The error removes Tillich's central mechanism. Participation, opening levels of reality/self, collective origin and mortality distinguish symbol from sign. A symbol still points beyond itself and must not absolutise its finite bearer.

Examiner trap 25: Tillich's symbol is not a convenient label; participation is the mechanism.

MCQ 26. Which correction should be made to the sentence "Scotus says God and creatures are ontologically beings in exactly the same way"?

A. Scotus rejects any common concept, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. B. Scotus is defending Maimonidean negation, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, as the decisive criterion. C. Scotus defends semantic univocity of the concept, qualified by finite/infinite intrinsic modes, not identical ontological being, with qualification. D. Replace "Scotus" with "Ayer.", as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Scotus rejects any common concept, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. This is the highest-frequency univocity trap. The common concept protects inference; intrinsic modes protect the ontological gulf, and "being" is not treated as a genus containing God.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Scotus is defending Maimonidean negation, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. This is the highest-frequency univocity trap. The common concept protects inference; intrinsic modes protect the ontological gulf, and "being" is not treated as a genus containing God.
- **C:** Correct: This is the highest-frequency univocity trap. The common concept protects inference; intrinsic modes protect the ontological gulf, and "being" is not treated as a genus containing God.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Replace "Scotus" with "Ayer.", as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, across all descriptive and ritual contexts alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. This is the highest-frequency univocity trap. The common concept protects inference; intrinsic modes protect the ontological gulf, and "being" is not treated as a genus containing God.

Examiner trap 26: Scotist univocity is semantic; intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference.

MCQ 27. Which sentence correctly repairs the claim "Advaita calls Brahman anirvacanīya because Brahman is neither real nor unreal"?

A. *Māyā* is technically *anirvacanīya* as neither absolutely real nor unreal; Brahman is *sat* but beyond objectifying speech, under the stated distinction. B. Brahman is an empirically verifiable object, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. C. Advaita calls both Brahman and *māyā* unreal, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. D. *Anirvacanīya* is a synonym for *sphoṭa*, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: The correction distinguishes ontological indeterminability from ineffability. Brahman defeats objectifying predication; *māyā* defeats classification under the real/unreal binary because it appears but is sublated.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Brahman is an empirically verifiable object, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. The correction distinguishes ontological indeterminability from ineffability. Brahman defeats objectifying predication; *māyā* defeats classification under the real/unreal binary because it appears but is sublated.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Advaita calls both Brahman and *māyā* unreal, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. The correction distinguishes ontological indeterminability from ineffability. Brahman defeats objectifying predication; *māyā* defeats classification under the real/unreal binary because it appears but is sublated.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "*Anirvacanīya* is a synonym for *sphoṭa*, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. The correction distinguishes ontological indeterminability from ineffability. Brahman defeats objectifying predication; *māyā* defeats classification under the real/unreal binary because it appears but is sublated.

Examiner trap 27: Brahman is non-objectifiable but *sat*; *māyā* is technically *anirvacanīya*.

MCQ 28. A student attributes *sphoṭa* and *śabda-nityatva* together to Mīmāṃsā. What is the accurate repair?

A. Both belong exclusively to Nyāya, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. B. Both belong exclusively to Advaita, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. C. *Sphoṭa* belongs to Tillich and *śabda-nityatva* to Austin, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation. D. Mīmāṃsā stresses *vidhi* and *śabda-nityatva*; *sphoṭa* is a grammarian doctrine associated with Bhartṛhari.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Both belong exclusively to Nyāya, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. The distinction matters because the topic uses Mīmāṃsā to illustrate injunctive and liturgical function, not a generic Indian philosophy of language assembled from different schools.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Both belong exclusively to Advaita, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. The distinction matters because the topic uses Mīmāṃsā to illustrate injunctive and liturgical function, not a generic Indian philosophy of language assembled from different schools.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "*Sphoṭa* belongs to Tillich and *śabda-nityatva* to Austin, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation.". It fails the controlling distinction. The distinction matters because the topic uses Mīmāṃsā to illustrate injunctive and liturgical function, not a generic Indian philosophy of language assembled from different schools.
- **D:** Correct: The distinction matters because the topic uses Mīmāṃsā to illustrate injunctive and liturgical function, not a generic Indian philosophy of language assembled from different schools.

Examiner trap 28: Do not attribute *sphoṭa* to Mīmāṃsā merely because both analyse language.

MCQ 29. In answering the 2024 20-mark question marked 10+10, which structure is mandatory?

A. Discuss only Braithwaite's biography, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification. B. Allocate one balanced part to the cognitive/non-cognitive distinction and one to the alleged contradiction with Braithwaite's response, with qualification. C. Treat the marks split as optional metadata, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context. D. Spend nearly the whole answer defining symbolism, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Discuss only Braithwaite's biography, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. Demand fidelity includes marks allocation. The second half must identify why factual meaning plus evidential immunity appears contradictory and decide whether analogical, defeasible cognitivism can avoid the problem.
- **B:** Correct: Demand fidelity includes marks allocation. The second half must identify why factual meaning plus evidential immunity appears contradictory and decide whether analogical, defeasible cognitivism can avoid the problem.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Treat the marks split as optional metadata, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, in every context.". It fails the controlling distinction. Demand fidelity includes marks allocation. The second half must identify why factual meaning plus evidential immunity appears contradictory and decide whether analogical, defeasible cognitivism can avoid the problem.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Spend nearly the whole answer defining symbolism, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling distinction. Demand fidelity includes marks allocation. The second half must identify why factual meaning plus evidential immunity appears contradictory and decide whether analogical, defeasible cognitivism can avoid the problem.

Examiner trap 29: The 2024 question is 10+10: distinguish first, then address contradiction.

MCQ 30. Which statement correctly distinguishes Hare and Mitchell?

A. Hare's *blik* is non-factual orientation; Mitchell's partisan models truth-apt, defeasible trust that acknowledges contrary evidence. B. Mitchell accepts Ayer's meaninglessness conclusion, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. C. Both deny that religious commitments encounter counterevidence, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike. D. Hare proposes eschatological verification, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Their replies to Flew are not interchangeable. Hare saves significance by giving up ordinary factual vulnerability; Mitchell saves cognition by allowing adverse evidence to count without requiring immediate abandonment.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Mitchell accepts Ayer's meaninglessness conclusion, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Their replies to Flew are not interchangeable. Hare saves significance by giving up ordinary factual vulnerability; Mitchell saves cognition by allowing adverse evidence to count without requiring immediate abandonment.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "Both deny that religious commitments encounter counterevidence, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike.". It fails the controlling distinction. Their replies to Flew are not interchangeable. Hare saves significance by giving up ordinary factual vulnerability; Mitchell saves cognition by allowing adverse evidence to count without requiring immediate abandonment.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Hare proposes eschatological verification, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, under the theory's own terms.". It fails the controlling

distinction. Their replies to Flew are not interchangeable. Hare saves significance by giving up ordinary factual vulnerability; Mitchell saves cognition by allowing adverse evidence to count without requiring immediate abandonment.

Examiner trap 30: Hare's blik ignores counterevidence as factual; Mitchell concedes it counts.

MCQ 31. Which claim about symbolism and mysticism is most defensible?

A. Every symbol necessarily culminates in unmediated experience, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification. B. Only Western traditions use symbols as graded practices, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, as the decisive criterion. C. Symbolism is a normal but non-necessary route; it may be transcended, may arrest in idolatry, or may constitutively shape experience, with qualification. D. Mysticism and symbolism are unrelated, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Every symbol necessarily culminates in unmediated experience, while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.". It fails the controlling distinction. The answer combines Tillich's participatory route, the idolatry/demonic warning, Indian *Om* and *upāsanā*, and Katz's constructivism. It avoids both automatic progression and total disconnection.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Only Western traditions use symbols as graded practices, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, as the decisive criterion.". It fails the controlling distinction. The answer combines Tillich's participatory route, the idolatry/demonic warning, Indian *Om* and *upāsanā*, and Katz's constructivism. It avoids both automatic progression and total disconnection.
- **C:** Correct: The answer combines Tillich's participatory route, the idolatry/demonic warning, Indian *Om* and *upāsanā*, and Katz's constructivism. It avoids both automatic progression and total disconnection.
- **D:** Incorrect: this option states "Mysticism and symbolism are unrelated, as an unrestricted rule for reference, truth-status, context, practice and commitment alike, without any independent role for evidence, context or practice.". It fails the controlling distinction. The answer combines Tillich's participatory route, the idolatry/demonic warning, Indian *Om* and *upāsanā*, and Katz's constructivism. It avoids both automatic progression and total disconnection.

Examiner trap 31: Symbolism is normal but non-necessary; idolatry, Katz and iconoclasm block inevitability.

MCQ 32. Which factual statement is safest in a high-scoring answer?

A. Tillich's non-symbolic exception remained unchanged and uncontested, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference. B. Non-literal semantics dissolves every conflict between religions, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment. C. D. Z. Phillips straightforwardly accepted the label "non-cognitivist.", while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification. D. Phillips rejected reductionist labelling; Tillich's exception is disputed; and some inter-religious existence-claims remain hard contradictions, under the stated distinction.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this option states "Tillich's non-symbolic exception remained unchanged and uncontested, as the sole criterion of meaning and reference.". It fails the controlling distinction. The option combines three attribution cautions. Precision earns marks: do not force Phillips into a box, do not present Tillich's evolving exception as settled, and do not turn semantic humility into indiscriminate harmonisation.
- **B:** Incorrect: this option states "Non-literal semantics dissolves every conflict between religions, as a sufficient account of reference, truth, use and commitment.". It fails the controlling distinction. The option combines three attribution cautions. Precision earns marks: do not force Phillips into a box, do not present Tillich's evolving exception as settled, and do not turn semantic humility into indiscriminate harmonisation.
- **C:** Incorrect: this option states "D. Z. Phillips straightforwardly accepted the label "non-cognitivist.", while excluding all competing roles for evidence, context, practice and interpretation, without qualification.". It fails the controlling

distinction. The option combines three attribution cautions. Precision earns marks: do not force Phillips into a box, do not present Tillich's evolving exception as settled, and do not turn semantic humility into indiscriminate harmonisation.

- **D:** Correct: The option combines three attribution cautions. Precision earns marks: do not force Phillips into a box, do not present Tillich's evolving exception as settled, and do not turn semantic humility into indiscriminate harmonisation.

Examiner trap 32: Tillich modified the exception, and Phillips resisted reductionist classification.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 14 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Exact wording and marks are controlled by the verified 2018-2025 Philosophy of Religion ledger.

PYQ 1 - 2018 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use of language? Discuss.

Demand decoding: "In what sense" requires named axes plus continuity; do not hunt for a sacred vocabulary.

Model solution: Religious and secular discourse largely share words such as "father," "light" and "knowledge"; their difference is primarily one of **function, referent, verification and self-involvement**. Secular sentences commonly describe or predict publicly identifiable states. Religious utterances may also worship, confess, bless or vow. Austin's performative analysis explains why "I take refuge in the Buddha" enacts commitment, while Evans calls such speech self-involving.

Reference also differs: religious predicates concern transcendence, so Ramsey's ordinary **model** plus stretching **qualifier** explains non-literal disclosure. Verification may be experiential or eschatological rather than immediately observational. Yet the contrast is not absolute: scripture can contain historical assertions, and secular oaths are performative.

Religious language is therefore a tradition-formed, symbolically stretched and characteristically committing use of ordinary language-not a separate vocabulary or a licence to abandon logic.

Why this earns marks: It states the "use, not vocabulary" thesis, names the axes, links examples to analysis and qualifies the contrast.

PYQ 2 - 2018 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Critically examine Braithwaite's non-cognitive theory of religious language.

Demand decoding: Reconstruct the moral-conative view before testing reductionism; distinguish Ayer, Hare and Wittgenstein.

Model solution: Braithwaite's *An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief* (1955) accepts that unverifiable theology cannot function like an ordinary empirical hypothesis but rejects Ayer's conclusion that religion is meaningless. A religious assertion principally declares commitment to a **moral policy**, sustained by stories. "God is love" avows an **agapeistic** way of life; narrative supplies models and motivation.

The theory explains why creed and conduct are connected and why religious language is self-involving. Austin and Evans support this practical insight: utterances can commit and constitute relationships rather than merely report facts.

Its weakness is reductionism. Believers normally intend both moral commitment and a claim about reality. Removing the latter produces an "atheist's account of religion"; a secular humanist could adopt agape without the creed. Nor are lament, prayer, creation, resurrection and mystical negation all moral policies. Hare's *blik* and Wittgensteinian grammar cannot simply be folded into Braithwaite.

Braithwaite may reply that practice is the publicly intelligible core. That preserves significance but not assertoric intention. His account is best retained within a mixed speech-act theory: religious utterances can be moral-commissive and truth-apt.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs Braithwaite fairly, distinguishes adjacent non-cognitivism, evaluates believer intent and ends with a defended mixed verdict.

PYQ 3 - 2018 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the significance of religious symbols as transcendent referent that mediates into the cultural, spatial and temporal world.

Demand decoding: Explain mediation across all three demanded dimensions; Tillich's participation is central.

Model solution: A religious symbol is a finite bearer through which a community apprehends transcendence. Its significance lies in **mediation**: it makes a non-ostensible referent culturally intelligible, spatially encounterable and temporally repeatable without identifying the bearer with the ultimate.

Tillich distinguishes symbol from sign. A sign points conventionally; a symbol **participates**, opens levels of reality and self, transforms the participant, arises collectively and can die. Thus cross, temple, sacred narrative or *Om* can mediate ultimate concern.

Culturally, symbols embody myths, ethics and memory; Ricoeur's "the symbol gives rise to thought" marks interpretive surplus. Spatially, Eliade's **hierophany** turns a place or object into sacred orientation, enabling worship and pilgrimage. Temporally, festivals and liturgy re-present an originating event to later generations.

The danger is arrest: a finite bearer claiming ultimacy becomes idolatrous or **demonic**. Conversely, a wholly indeterminate symbol loses reference. Symbols are bridges, not photographs: valid when they disclose and point beyond themselves, criticisable when they conceal or absolutise their cultural form.

Why this earns marks: It explains the mechanism, covers cultural/spatial/temporal mediation and qualifies disclosure through idolatry and vague-reference controls.

PYQ 4 - 2019 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss whether and how does religious symbolism lead to mysticism.

Demand decoding: Answer both "whether" and "how": route the mechanism, then give the negative case.

Model solution: Religious symbolism can lead to mysticism when a finite symbol mediates participation and then becomes transparent to what it signifies. It is neither necessary nor guaranteed: symbols may arrest consciousness, and constructivists deny that experience ever escapes mediation.

How the route works. Tillich's symbol participates and opens levels of reality and self. Contemplative use draws the practitioner beyond information toward involvement. Ricoeur's "symbol gives rise to thought" describes the interpretive beginning; his second naïvete permits post-critical re-inhabitation. Pseudo-Dionysius gives the sequence: cataphatic names are affirmed, then negated apophatically, culminating in mystical unknowing.

Indian materials make the graded mechanism precise. Symbol or image worship (*pratīka/pratimā upāsana*) can prepare movement from qualified (*saguṇa*) devotion to the unqualified (*nirguṇa*). In the *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad*, A-U-M corresponds to waking, dream and deep sleep; the soundless fourth (*amātra, turīya*) is the culmination beyond articulated sound. Mantra and diagram (*yantra*) may be internalised and dissolved.

Why it may fail. Literalisation makes the symbol idolatrous or demonic. Katz argues that symbols constitute mystical experience rather than lead to an unmediated terminus. Zen iconoclasm and *neti neti* delete images; ethics, inquiry and grace are alternative routes.

Symbolism is therefore a normal but non-necessary path, successful only when participatory practice is joined to self-effacement.

Why this earns marks: It fulfils both directives, links named evidence to the four-stage route and includes arrest, constructivism and non-necessity.

PYQ 5 - 2020 · Q8(a) · 20 marks

Exact verified question: Does religious language carry cognitive content? Elucidate in detail.

Demand decoding: Give a defended spectrum, empirical objections, non-cognitive accounts and a mixed conclusion.

Model solution: Religious language carries cognitive content when utterances purport to state what is true or false of reality, but its cognition is rarely crude literal description. A sentence can be assertoric, analogical or symbolic, expressive and performative at once.

The realist case begins with believer intention. Aquinas holds that a perfection's **thing signified** (*res significata*) applies truly while the creaturely **mode of signification** (*modus significandi*) remains inadequate. Tillich's symbolic realism claims participation in being-itself; Ramsey's model-and-qualifier preserves continuity. Hick's celestial-city parable makes an assertion truth-apt now though possibly verified only eschatologically.

Ayer challenges this through verification. Flew asks what could count against divine love; endless qualification may empty content. Hare replies with a life-shaping *blik*, while Mitchell's partisan protects cognition by admitting adverse evidence counts.

Braithwaite reads belief as an agapeistic moral policy. Wittgensteinian approaches locate meaning in grammar and form of life; Phillips resisted a simple non-cognitivist label. Austin and Evans show that confession, blessing and vow enact commitments.

The cost of pure non-cognitivism is reductionism; the cost of literalism is anthropomorphism and evidential immunity. A mixed account is strongest: defeasible truth-claims signified analogically or symbolically and joined to expressive or commissive acts.

Why this earns marks: It maps the spectrum, attaches named evidence to each claim and defends a position that preserves realism and critical vulnerability.

PYQ 6 - 2021 · Q8(a) · 20 marks

Exact verified question: What is non-cognitive theory of religious language? Explain critically in the light of R. B. Braithwaite's views.

Demand decoding: Define the family, state Braithwaite's version and evaluate it against believer intent.

Model solution: A non-cognitive theory denies that factual description is the primary or valid function of religious language. The family is diverse: Ayer calls unverifiable theology meaningless; Hare's *blik* is an unfalsifiable orientation; Wittgensteinian approaches study grammar and use. Braithwaite offers a specifically **moral-conative** account.

In *An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief* (1955), Braithwaite interprets "God is love" as a declaration of intention to follow an **agapeistic policy**. Religious stories sustain that commitment through exemplary patterns; their practical role need not depend on ordinary empirical verification. The theory saves meaning from Ayer and explains the bond between creed and conduct.

Its strengths are self-involvement and practical seriousness. Yet it mistakes an important illocutionary force for total semantic content. Believers generally mean that God exists and loves, not only that they intend to love. If stories disclose nothing real, their distinctive authority becomes unclear; a secular person can adopt agape. Prayer, lament, resurrection and apophatic speech also resist reduction to one policy.

Braithwaite differs from Hare's world-picture and from Phillips, who denied reducing grammar to attitude. Mitchell and Hick preserve truth-aptness while widening evidential standards.

Thus Braithwaite supplies valuable pragmatics but inadequate total semantics. A mixed account should retain moral commitment, analogical or symbolic assertion and vulnerability to reasons.

Why this earns marks: It defines the family, locates Braithwaite precisely, develops distinct objections and preserves his insight in a better theory.

PYQ 7 - 2021 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the symbolic nature of religious language with special reference to Paul Tillich.

Demand decoding: Explain Tillich's criteria, being-itself and dangers; preserve the disputed exception.

Model solution: Tillich calls religious language symbolic because ultimate concern cannot be captured as one finite object. A symbol is not decorative metaphor or conventional sign. It points beyond itself while **participating** in what it indicates, opens levels of reality and self, grows from collective life, transforms participants and can die.

Accordingly, "Father," cross or sacred narrative mediates ultimate concern rather than literally classifying God as a magnified being. God is not the highest being but **being-itself**. Literalising a finite bearer makes it ultimate and therefore idolatrous; Tillich calls this distortion **demonic**.

The theory respects transcendence while explaining existential force and cultural plurality. Its weakness is referential vagueness: what exactly does participation mean? Tillich treated "God is being-itself" as a non-symbolic anchor, but later modified the position; its status is disputed.

Aquinas provides a contrast: analogy stresses ordered semantic content through causal participation, whereas Tillich stresses existential disclosure. Symbolic language is meaningful and potentially cognitive only when its referent and communal criteria remain disciplined and the symbol points beyond, rather than demands worship for, its finite form.

Why this earns marks: It gives Tillich's full mechanism and ontology, qualifies the exception and tests symbolic realism through a precise comparator.

PYQ 8 - 2022 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the difference between the cognitivist and non-cognitivist approaches to the religious language with reference to the statement - "God exists".

Demand decoding: Apply both accounts directly to "God exists"; distinguish truth-aptness from practical force.

Model solution: The distinction concerns whether "God exists" states something true or false. A **cognitivist** treats it as an assertion about reality. Aquinas preserves reference analogically; Hick treats the claim as truth-apt now and possibly verified eschatologically. Cognitivism matches believer intention but faces Ayer's verification challenge and Flew's demand for counterevidence.

A **non-cognitivist** relocates meaning. Braithwaite hears commitment to an agapeistic policy; Hare treats belief as a life-shaping *blik*; Wittgensteinian approaches examine its grammar in worship and hope, though Phillips rejected simple reductionism. Ayer's hostile version calls it meaningless.

These accounts need not exhaust one another. "God exists" can assert reality, use analogical or symbolic predicates, express trust and commit conduct. The most adequate analysis is mixed: practical force supplements rather than cancels cognitive intent.

Why this earns marks: It applies every distinction to the stated sentence, separates semantic mode from truth-status and adjudicates with a clear mixed position.

PYQ 9 - 2023 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss Wittgenstein's view about the non-cognitive nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Explain meaning-as-use and Last Judgement, then qualify the non-cognitive attribution.

Model solution: Wittgenstein's lectures shift attention from an isolated sentence's empirical test to its **use** in religious life. Belief in the Last Judgement does not function merely as a forecast like tomorrow's weather; it organises repentance, hope, fear and conduct. Later Wittgensteinian approaches express this through language-game, grammar and form of life.

The view is called non-cognitive because it resists treating prayer or belief as detached scientific hypothesis. Yet the label is contested. Wittgenstein offered no single reductive theory, and D. Z. Phillips denied that clarifying religious grammar made beliefs fictional or meaningless.

Its strength is contextual accuracy; its risk is fideistic insulation if internal use makes external evidence irrelevant. Mitchell's defeasible trust supplies a corrective. Wittgensteinian analysis therefore shows that religious meaning exceeds description, not that every religious claim lacks cognitive content.

Why this earns marks: It explains use and form of life through the correct example, protects attribution discipline and answers the insulation objection.

PYQ 10 - 2023 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the symbolic nature of religious language according to Tillich.

Demand decoding: Reconstruct participation, disclosure and being-itself; test reference and idolatry.

Model solution: For Tillich, religious language is symbolic because finite literal concepts cannot contain ultimate concern. A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol points beyond itself while **participating**, opens reality and self, arises collectively, transforms and may grow or die.

Names such as Father, Kingdom or cross therefore mediate rather than photograph transcendence. God is not a being within the totality but **being-itself**. This prevents anthropomorphic literalism and explains existential transformation. It also explains distortion: when a conditioned image claims unconditional validity, it becomes idolatrous or **demonic**.

The account preserves positive language without reducing God to an object. Yet participation is obscure and can make reference vague. If all God-talk is symbolic, the assertion that it is symbolic appears to need a non-symbolic basis. Tillich proposed "God is being-itself" as that basis, but later modified the position; its coherence remains disputed.

Aquinas' analogy clarifies the difference: causal participation orders perfection-terms, while Tillich stresses existential disclosure. Tillich shows how non-literal language can be meaningful, but symbolic realism remains defensible only where interpretation is constrained and the symbol stays self-transcending.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs all central Tillichian claims, uses analogy as a discriminator and gives a qualified referential verdict.

PYQ 11 - 2024 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the analogical nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Frame the dilemma, state Aquinas's mechanism, example, objection and verdict.

Model solution: Aquinas uses analogy to avoid two failures. Univocal predication makes God a finite member of a shared category; complete equivocity makes God-talk unintelligible. Analogy preserves ordered similarity-with-difference.

Pure perfections such as goodness exist in God **essentially and eminently**. Their **thing signified** (*res significata*) applies truly, while the creature-derived **mode of signification** (*modus significandi*) remains inadequate. Later Thomists distinguish attribution-"healthy" said primarily of an animal and derivatively of medicine-from proportionality, where goodness belongs according to divine and creaturely modes. This taxonomy is especially Cajetanian, not Aquinas's fixed formula.

Scotus objects that inference needs a univocal concept; Aquinas replies that causal participation supplies continuity without placing God in a genus. Analogy therefore secures realist meaning without literal anthropomorphism, though its standing cost is indeterminacy.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing dilemma, uses the exact technical pair and taxonomy caution, and answers the strongest rival.

PYQ 12 - 2024 · Q8(a) · 20 marks (10+10)

Exact verified question: Distinguish between cognitivist and non-cognitivist account of religious language. Does the cognitivist account lead to any contradiction? Answer with reference to the philosophical views of R. B. Braithwaite.

Demand decoding: Respect the 10+10 split: distinguish first; then assess the alleged contradiction and Braithwaite's solution.

Model solution: Part I - distinction. Cognitivism treats "God exists" or "God is good" as truth-apt. Aquinas preserves reference analogically; Mitchell treats faith as defeasible trust; Hick allows eschatological verification. Non-cognitivism denies that fact-stating is primary or legitimate, but includes Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's *blik*, Wittgensteinian use and Braithwaite's moral-conative account.

Braithwaite interprets "God is love" as commitment to an **agapeistic policy** sustained by stories. Cognitivism asks what reality the statement describes; Braithwaite asks what conduct its avowal commits one to. These may be dimensions of one utterance rather than exclusive meanings.

Part II - contradiction assessed. The pressure appears when a believer claims divine love factually while allowing no suffering to count against it. Flew's invisible gardener shows how endless qualifications preserve words but remove evidential content; Ayer adds the verification problem. This is not a formal contradiction inherent in cognitivism but a danger of **evidential immunity**.

Braithwaite avoids it by relocating meaning to policy, but believers ordinarily intend a claim about God, and agape can be adopted without theology. His analysis cannot exhaust prayer, resurrection, lament or negation.

Mitchell offers a better middle: commitment survives ambiguity while adverse evidence genuinely counts. A mixed account can preserve analogical or symbolic assertion, moral commitment and defeasibility. Cognitivism becomes contradictory only when truth-claim is combined with total evidential invulnerability.

Why this earns marks: It obeys the marks split, identifies evidential immunity rather than inventing formal contradiction, and evaluates Braithwaite directly.

PYQ 13 - 2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Is religious language symbolic? Give reasons and justification in support of your answer.

Demand decoding: Take a position, rank reasons through Tillich, and qualify symbolic mode against total non-cognitivism.

Model solution: Religious language is characteristically symbolic because transcendence cannot be presented as one finite observable object; but symbolic mode does not mean absence of cognitive intent.

Tillich's symbol differs from a sign: it **participates**, opens levels of reality and self, transforms, arises collectively and can die. "Father," light or cross mediates ultimate concern rather than literally classifying God. God is not one being among others but being-itself; an absolutised finite symbol becomes idolatrous or demonic.

Symbols also explain existential force and cultural plurality. The *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* makes *Om* a graded symbol whose soundless fourth points beyond articulated sound.

Yet participation can be vague, and prayers, vows and assertions have different forces. Tillich's disputed being-itself exception shows the need for referential discipline. Religious language is substantially symbolic in mode, while often retaining assertoric and performative dimensions.

Why this earns marks: It gives a ranked yes-but case, uses Tillich and the *Māṇḍūkya* example, and preserves mixed speech functions.

PYQ 14 - 2025 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the Advaitic notion of indescribability (anirvacanīyatā) in the context of nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Treat anirvacanīyatā as predication; distinguish māyā from Brahman and explain negation, indication and sublation.

Model solution: Advaita distinguishes two linguistic limits. Brahman is beyond objectifying speech-ineffable or *avācya*-whereas **anirvacanīya** *technically characterises* māyā*, ignorance and world-appearance as neither absolutely real nor unreal.

The world appears and has transactional validity, so it is not unreal like a hare's horn; it is sublated by knowledge of Brahman, so it is not ultimately real. It is therefore *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa* and defeats binary classification. Brahman, by contrast, is *sat* and non-objectifiable; it is not indeterminable in *māyā*'s sense.

Language still has a disciplined role. "Not this, not this" (*neti neti*; Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6) removes limiting predicates. "Whence words turn back" (*yaṭo vāco nivartante*; Taittirīya 2.9) marks objectification's limit. Indirect indication (*lakṣaṇā*) preserves intended import: in *tat tvam asi*, *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness.

The self-reference objection says that calling Brahman indescribable describes it. Advaita replies that such language is therapeutic: like one thorn removing another, it removes error and is itself sublated. Advaitic religious language is eliminative and indicative, not mere silence or emotivism.

Why this earns marks: It preserves the decisive Brahman/māyā distinction, explains each semantic operation and answers self-reference with sublation.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE - 6 MODELS

These are original learner-practice questions, not UPSC PYQs.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "Analogy protects transcendence only by sacrificing intelligibility." Examine with reference to Aquinas and Scotus. (Answer within 150 words.)

Demand decoding: Test the quotation through Aquinas's mechanism, Scotus's objection and a graded verdict.

Model answer: The charge identifies analogy's risk but overstates its failure. Aquinas rejects anthropomorphic univocity and empty equivocity. Pure perfection exists in God essentially and eminently: the *res significata* applies truly, while creaturely *modus significandi* remains inadequate. Causal participation supplies ordered continuity.

Scotus objects that inference requires a semantically univocal concept of being; otherwise analogy disguises equivocation. His certain-and-doubtful argument allows one to be certain that God is a being while doubtful whether finite or infinite. Intrinsic modes restore ontological difference.

The Thomist reply is that causal dependence, not a common genus, grounds the middle term. Yet analogy must explain how its proportion is fixed. It preserves **qualified intelligibility**, not transparency. A defensible conclusion combines analogical predication, enough conceptual continuity for inference, and an apophatic limit on adequacy.

Why this earns marks: It converts the quotation into the inference/transcendence trade-off, gives Scotus's strongest argument and reaches a qualified synthesis.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Can religious utterances be performative without ceasing to be cognitive? Discuss. (Answer within 150 words.)

Demand decoding: Separate illocutionary force from truth-aptness and use concrete speech acts.

Model answer: Yes. "Performative" concerns what an utterance does; "cognitive" concerns whether it also expresses a truth-apt proposition. The dimensions need not conflict.

Austin distinguishes locutionary content from illocutionary force. "I take refuge in the Buddha," baptism, vow or ritual resolve (*saṃkalpa*) performs an act under appropriate conditions. Evans calls such speech self-involving because it

commits conduct and constitutes relationships.

These acts carry presuppositions: prayer normally presupposes an addressee; thanksgiving a benefactor; baptism a community and authority. "God is love" may assert something while committing the speaker to agape. Braithwaite captures commitment but reduces assertion.

A mixed speech-act account is therefore preferable. Religious language can be assertoric, symbolic and commissive together, provided practical commitment does not become immunity from evidence or criticism.

Why this earns marks: It separates truth-aptness from force, uses concrete evidence and states the condition under which performance remains cognitive.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Compare the via negativa of Maimonides with Advaita's *neti neti*. Do they end in meaningful discourse or silence? (Answer within 250 words.)

Demand decoding: Compare grounds, permitted speech and self-reference; include action-attributes and *lakṣaṇā*.

Model answer: Maimonides and Advaita use negation to prevent finite predicates from objectifying the ultimate, but neither begins or ends with mute scepticism.

In *Guide for the Perplexed* 1.50-60, Maimonides denies positive essential attributes because they compromise divine simplicity. Legitimate speech consists of **negations**-God is not ignorant-and **attributes of action**-God is called merciful from effects rather than a creature-like quality. Negation removes error while action-language sustains ethical discourse.

Advaita's "not this, not this" (*neti neti*; Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6) removes limiting identifications. Brahman remains *sat*, not nothing. Advaita also supplies indirect indication (*lakṣaṇā*): in *tat tvam asi*, *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness.

Both face vacuity and self-reference: "the ultimate is indescribable" seems descriptive. Maimonides answers through determinate negations and effects; Advaita treats language as a thorn removing ignorance, itself sublated after knowledge.

They end in disciplined silence, not meaninglessness. Their termini differ: Maimonides preserves Creator-creature distance; Advaita culminates in non-dual recognition.

Why this earns marks: It compares metaphysical grounds and permitted speech, answers self-reference and directly adjudicates the silence question.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "The meaning of religious language is exhausted neither by truth-conditions nor by use." Critically discuss. (Answer within 250 words.)

Demand decoding: Show what truth-condition and use theories explain and defend a mixed account.

Model answer: The statement is persuasive because religious discourse is heterogeneous. Truth-conditions matter where believers assert that God exists or liberation is possible; use matters where they pray, vow, confess or orient a life.

Cognitivism preserves believer intent. Aquinas shows that truth-aptness need not mean univocal literalism: the perfection signified applies while the creaturely mode remains inadequate. Hick and Mitchell preserve truth through possible verification and defeasible trust. Yet truth-conditions alone under-describe illocutionary force.

Austin and Evans show that utterances act and involve the speaker. Ramsey explains disclosure through model and qualifier; Mīmāṃsā's injunction (*vidhi*) and mantra reveal practical organisation. Wittgensteinian grammar makes these uses intelligible within a form of life.

Use alone is insufficient. Braithwaite's agapeistic policy captures commitment but omits the intended claim about God. Phillips therefore resisted reductionist non-cognitivism. Internal grammar also cannot make external evidence or moral criticism irrelevant.

A mixed account is strongest: identify proposition, semantic mode, illocutionary force and practice together. Religious utterances may be assertoric, analogical, symbolic, expressive and commissive without one dimension exhausting the others.

Why this earns marks: It states each theory's gain and cost, uses named evidence analytically and defends an integrated semantics/pragmatics verdict.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Develop and defend a mixed account of religious language against both verificationist elimination and fideistic insulation. (*Answer within 350 words.*)

Demand decoding: Construct a positive account, answer both errors, integrate Indian resources and state a defeater.

Model answer: A defensible theory must preserve four facts: believers intend assertions; transcendent reference exceeds literal description; utterances also worship and commit; and claims remain answerable to reasons. A **mixed account** analyses proposition, semantic mode, speech act and practice together.

Against verificationist elimination, Ayer wrongly equates factual meaning with present empirical testability. Aquinas shows how analogical predication can remain truth-apt; Hick's eschatological verification distinguishes present evidence from verification in principle. Flew's challenge remains valuable: a cognitive claim must acknowledge what counts against it. Mitchell's partisan models defeasible trust rather than immunity.

Against fideistic insulation, Wittgensteinian grammar correctly explains why Last Judgement belief is not merely a forecast. But internal use cannot make a practice self-validating; Phillips himself rejected crude reductionism. Religious language overlaps with public moral and factual life.

Speech-act analysis supplies the synthesis. Austin distinguishes locution from illocution; Evans shows self-involvement. "God is love" can assert analogically, express trust and commit agape. Tillich adds symbolic participation; Ramsey adds model and qualifier.

Indian materials confirm functional plurality. Advaita uses eliminative negation (*neti neti*) and indirect indication (*lakṣaṇā*); Mīmāṃsā gives injunction priority without making every sentence imperative; Jain conditional predication states the respect.

The account's defeater would be proof that no religious utterance genuinely intends reference, or that every proposed referent is semantically empty. Short of that, mixed realism best preserves meaning, practice and critical vulnerability.

Why this earns marks: It constructs rather than merely surveys a theory, answers both opposing failures, integrates Indian mechanisms and states a genuine defeater.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: How does a theory of religious language shape the possibility of religious pluralism? Critically examine. (*Answer within 350 words.*)

Demand decoding: Trace semantics to rival truth-claims, compare Hick, Advaita and Jainism, then preserve hard contradictions.

Model answer: Religious pluralism is downstream of religious semantics. How traditions speak about ultimate reality determines whether rival claims are direct contradictions, partial descriptions or incommensurable practices.

If God-talk is univocal and literal, descriptions are directly comparable: "a personal creator exists" and "no personal creator exists" cannot both be true in the same respect. Exclusivism follows naturally unless one claim is rejected. If language is analogical, symbolic or apophatic, finite formulations need not exhaust their referent; plural descriptions may be mode-relative without truth becoming relative.

Hick makes this bridge explicit. The Real *an sich* is transcategorical, while traditions experience personal and non-personal **personae/impersonae** through cultural schemes. Remove that limit-of-predication thesis and his pluralism collapses. Yet it inherits the apophatic objection: a Real of which nothing substantial is said may be indistinguishable from nothing.

Advaita provides two-level semantics: Brahman without qualities (*nirguṇa*) exceeds predication while with-qualities (*saguṇa*) forms structure devotion. Jain many-sidedness and conditional predication (*anekāntavāda*, *syādvāda*) specify the standpoint within the proposition, avoiding a retreat to unknowability. R̥gveda 1.164.46 supplies one referent/many names, but its inter-religious extension requires argument.

The limit is decisive. Non-literal semantics can route personal/non-personal descriptions but cannot dissolve creator/no-creator or survival/no-survival. A viable semantic pluralism combines non-exhaustive reference, specified

standpoints and acknowledgement of hard contradiction. It makes pluralism intelligible, not automatically true.

Why this earns marks: It traces a causal conceptual chain, uses three distinct models, states their objections and preserves the hard-contradiction boundary.

Question-shaped timed-paper compression plan

Demand	Protect	Cut first
Secular vs religious use	function/referent/self-involvement	long examples
Braithwaite	policy + stories + reductionism	minor comparators
Symbol mediation	participation + three dimensions	surplus illustrations
Symbol -> mysticism	mechanism + negative case	one secondary tradition
Cognitive content	spectrum + Flew/Mitchell + verdict	minor representatives
Tillich	sign/symbol + being-itself + caution	historical detail
Analogy	dilemma + res/modus + Scotus	extra comparisons
Advaita	Brahman/māyā + neti/lakṣaṇā	extended parity

Independence note

All explanations, model answers and marks rationales are independent learner material. UPSC publishes no official model answers for these questions.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Everything required for a competent answer is already complete. The four refinements below are second-order additions for a selective 15- or 20-marker.

A1 - Analogy versus metaphorical realism

Competing positions. Thomists defend structured analogical predication; metaphorical realists stress imaginative disclosure rather than quasi-literal proportion.

Objection -> reply. Analogy may remain too indeterminate to ground truth. Thomists reply through causal participation and ordered perfection-terms; critics still press semantic thinness.

Safe use. Add after-not instead of-the univocal/equivocal dilemma and Aquinas's res/modus account. A further historical add-on associated with Radical Orthodoxy, especially Milbank and Pickstock, connects Scotist univocity with secular metaphysics; present that genealogy as contested, never settled history.

A2 - Deferred verification versus evidential cheapness

Competing positions. Verificationists demand present testability; falsification critics demand vulnerability; Hick preserves possible future confirmation.

Objection -> reply. Eschatological verification appears too cheap because failure may be impossible to report. Reply: it still refutes the claim that no conceivable experience could verify religious belief, while leaving present warrant unsettled.

A3 - Expressivism and fictionalism versus realism

Competing positions. Expressivist or fictionalist views retain religious practice without full assertion; realists insist believers ordinarily make truth-claims.

Objection -> reply. Expressive readings misdescribe intention. Mixed speech-act theory replies that assertion, worship, commitment and narrative imagination can coexist without reducing one to another.

A4 - Advaita's indirect indication and the self-reference worry

Competing positions. Advaita uses negation and indirect indication to avoid objectifying Brahman; critics say "Brahman is ineffable" is self-defeating.

Objection -> reply. The sentence seems to predicate ineffability. Advaita treats it therapeutically: it removes ordinary predication and is itself sublated after knowledge. The reply protects function but remains dependent on the accepted non-dual framework.

What not to over-study

Do not chase every late analytic theory of metaphor, every speech-act taxonomy or the entire Radical Orthodoxy genealogy. Add one advanced refinement only after the printed theory and its mechanism are secure.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Twenty topic-specific revision cards follow the taught order and preserve the Core/Optional distinction.

1. Two-axis control

- HOW: univocal, analogical, symbolic, negative, indicative.
- WHETHER: cognitive, mixed, moral-conative, *blik*, use, meaningless.
- One utterance may be assertoric + symbolic + performative.
- Meaningfulness ≠ empirical factuality.
- First-line habit: identify the axis.

2. Univocal-equivocal dilemma

- Univocity: inference gain; anthropomorphism risk.
- Equivocity: transcendence gain; unintelligibility risk.
- Middle exits: analogy, symbol, negation; Scotus instead qualifies univocity.
- Any theory must preserve continuity and difference.

3. Aquinas I

- *Summa Theologiae* I q.13.
- Pure perfections in God essentially and eminently.
- *Res significata* applies truly; *modus significandi* remains inadequate.
- Causal participation grounds similarity.
- Never reduce "God is good" to "God causes goodness".

4. Aquinas II

- Attribution: ordered secondary uses; "healthy" animal/medicine example.
- Proportionality: perfection according to distinct modes.
- Pair = later Thomist, especially Cajetanian, systematisation.
- Cost: how is the proportion fixed?

5. Scotus

- Univocity is semantic/conceptual, not ontological.
- Certain God is a being; doubtful finite/infinite -> common concept.
- Intrinsic modes finite/infinite restore difference.
- Being is not a genus containing God.
- Exchange: inference versus anthropomorphism.

6. Maimonides

- *Guide* I.50-60: no positive essential attributes.
- Negations + attributes of action.
- Protects divine simplicity and transcendence.
- Standing cost: vacuity / inability to distinguish God from nothing.

7. Tillich

- Symbol ≠ sign: participation, disclosure, transformation, collective origin, death.
- God = being-itself, not highest being.
- Finite bearer claiming ultimacy -> idolatry / demonic.
- "Being-itself" non-symbolic anchor was modified; status disputed.
- Cost: vague referent and self-reference.

8. Ramsey, metaphor and myth

- Ordinary model + qualifier -> disclosure situation.
- Qualifier stretches, does not cancel, the model.
- Metaphor transfers pattern; myth narratively organises identity/value.
- Neither is identical to participatory symbol.

9. Speech acts and self-involvement

- Austin: locutionary / illocutionary / perlocutionary.
- Vow, refuge, baptism, blessing enact relations.
- Evans: religious avowal commits the speaker.
- Performance can carry cognitive presuppositions.
- Secular/religious difference: function, referent, verification, commitment-not vocabulary.

10. Ayer

- Verification challenge targets factual meaning, not merely truth.
- Weak verification allows probabilistic support.
- God-talk fails if no experience could count.
- Objections: self-application and over-restriction.

11. Flew-Hare-Mitchell-Hick

- Flew: invisible gardener; thousand qualifications.
- Hare: *blik*-important, non-factual orientation.
- Mitchell: partisan-defeasible trust; counterevidence counts.
- Hick: celestial city; eschatological verification.
- Key question: vulnerability to reasons.

12. Cognitive spectrum

- Literal realism -> analogy -> symbolic realism -> eschatological realism -> mixed speech acts -> use -> moral policy -> *blik* -> fictionalism -> Ayer.
- Cognitivism pressure: evidence/reference.
- Non-cognitivism pressure: reductionism.
- Preferred synthesis: qualified mixed realism.

13. Braithwaite

- 1955 moral-conative account.
- "God is love" -> agapeistic policy + stories.
- Gain: creed/conduct, practical seriousness.
- Cost: believer intent, theological disagreement, multiple speech acts.
- Keep insight; reject total reduction.

14. Wittgensteinian use

- Last Judgement ≠ ordinary weather prediction.
- Meaning through language-game, grammar, form of life.
- Phillips rejected simple non-cognitivism/reductionism.
- Cost: fideistic insulation.
- Clarification does not confer truth.

15. Advaita I

- Brahman: *sat*, non-objectifiable, ineffable (*avācya*).
- Māyā/world: *anirvacanīya*, *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*.
- Appearance prevents sheer unreality; sublation prevents ultimate reality.
- Never assign māyā's status to Brahman.

16. Advaita II and Indian controls

- *Neti neti*: eliminative negation.
- *Lakṣaṇā*: indirect indication.
- *Bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā*: discard incompatible connotations in *tat tvam asi*.
- Rāmānuja: real auspicious predicates.
- Madhyamaka: conventional meaning / no intrinsic nature.
- Jain *syādvāda*: state the respect.
- Nyāya: determinate God-predication is only a limited univocity heuristic.
- Mīmāṃsā: *vidhi*, mantra, *śabda-nityatva*; *sphoṭa* = grammarian/Bhartṛhari.

17. Symbol to mysticism

- Participation -> involvement -> transparency -> self-effacement -> claimed immediacy.
- Ricoeur: symbol gives rise to thought; second naïvete.
- Pseudo-Dionysius: cataphatic -> apophatic -> silence.
- *Om*: A-U-M -> waking/dream/deep sleep -> soundless *amātra/turīya*.
- Eliade: hierophany mediates the sacred through finite place/object.
- Tantric mantra/*yantra/maṇḍala* and Sufi *ishārāt*: instrumental/allusive routes.

18. Countercase to mysticism route

- Idolatry/demonic: symbol arrests.
- Katz: symbol constitutes experience.
- Zen / *neti neti*: iconoclastic subtraction.
- Ethics, inquiry, grace: alternative routes.
- Verdict: normal but neither necessary nor sufficient.

19. Pluralism bridge

- Univocal literalism -> direct contradiction/exclusivism.
- Analogy/symbol/apophasis -> non-exhaustive descriptions/pluralism possible.
- Hick's transcategorical Real is a semantic thesis and inherits vacuity.
- Advaita: *nirguṇa/saguṇa*; Jainism: standpoint inside proposition.
- Hard contradiction remains: creator/no creator; survival/no survival.

20. Answer architecture and final verdict

- 10m: define -> mechanism -> example -> objection -> verdict.
- 15m: doctrine -> presupposition -> comparison -> reply -> qualification.
- 20m: HOW/WHETHER -> spectrum -> evidence pressure -> Indian resource -> defended synthesis.
- Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification.
- Final formula: univocity/inference; analogy/transcendence; negation/purity; each has a cost.
- Qualified verdict: intelligible reference + apophatic humility + critical vulnerability.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/25: Official boundary and the two-axis control

SYLLABUS: Analogical and Symbolic; Cognitivist and Non-cognitive.

CENTRAL QUESTION: how can finite language refer to transcendence, and what does it claim?

HOW / SEMANTIC MODE: univocal | analogy | symbol | negation | indication

WHETHER / STATUS: cognitive | mixed | moral-conative | blik | use | meaningless

CONTROL: "God is good" may be ANALOGICAL in mode and COGNITIVE in intent.

Meaningfulness does not entail empirical factuality; performance does not cancel assertion.

FIREWALL: experience, revelation, pluralism and full school doctrines retain their owners.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/25: Semantic modes and speech functions

LITERAL / UNIVOCAL -> same conceptual sense; cognitive; anthropomorphism risk.

ANALOGICAL -> ordered similarity through causal participation or proportion.

METAPHORICAL -> imaginative transfer; may disclose indirectly.

SYMBOLIC -> participation + disclosure + transformation; truth-status depends on theory.

MYTHIC -> narrative organisation of world, identity and value.

NEGATIVE / APOPHATIC -> deny creaturely limits; vacuity risk.

PERFORMATIVE -> vow, blessing, confession or relation enacted under success-conditions.

EXPRESSIVE / PRESCRIPTIVE -> attitude or conduct; non-cognitive need not be meaningless.

ONE UTTERANCE can combine assertion, symbol, expression and commitment.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/25: The univocal-equivocal dilemma

UNIVOCITY

gain: valid inference and stable concept
cost: God appears as a finite member of a shared category

EQUIVOCITY

gain: radical transcendence
cost: no intelligible reference; inference equivocates

CLASSICAL EXITS

Aquinas -> analogy
Tillich -> participatory symbol
Maimonides / apophasis -> negation
Scotus -> semantic univocity + finite/infinite intrinsic modes

EXAM LINE: preserve enough continuity for reference and enough difference for transcendence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/25: Aquinas: essential and eminent predication

SOURCE: Summa Theologiae I q.13.

PURE PERFECTION (goodness, wisdom) exists in God ESSENTIALLY AND EMINENTLY.

thing signified (res significata) -> applies truly to God
mode of signification (modus significandi) -> creature-derived and inadequate

CAUSAL PARTICIPATION

effect resembles cause without possessing perfection in the same finite mode

AQUINAS REJECTS cause-only paraphrase:

not merely "God causes goodness"; God causes goodness because God is good.

GAIN: cognitive realism without crude literalism.

COST: how is analogical content fixed without prior knowledge of God?

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/25: Later Thomist analogy: attribution and proportionality

ATTRIBUTION

"healthy" primarily of animal; medicine as cause; complexion as sign
ordered secondary use -> illustrates relation, not whole divine goodness doctrine

PROPORTIONALITY

God has goodness according to infinite mode
creature has goodness according to finite mode

HISTORICAL CONTROL

familiar pair = later Thomist, especially Cajetanian, systematisation
do not present as Aquinas's unqualified fixed taxonomy

ENGINE remains causal participation + pure perfection.

TRAP: analogy is not metaphor, equivocation or cause-only naming.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/25: Duns Scotus: semantic univocity

CERTAIN/DOUBTFUL ARGUMENT

certain: God is a being
doubtful: finite or infinite?
therefore "being" is a concept neutral/common before modal specification

UNIVOCITY IS SEMANTIC, NOT ONTOLOGICAL.

being is not a genus containing God and creatures
finite / infinite intrinsic modes restore the ontological gulf

DUNS SCOTUS'S OBJECTION: analogy without common concept collapses into equivocation.

THOMIST REPLY: causal relation supplies ordered continuity.

TRADE-OFF: inference gained; anthropomorphism / onto-theology charge remains contested.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/25: Maimonides and negative theology

SOURCE: Guide for the Perplexed I.50-60.

POSITIVE ESSENTIAL ATTRIBUTES -> threaten divine simplicity -> rejected.

PERMITTED SPEECH

negations: God is not ignorant / not powerless

attributes of action: called merciful from effects, not creature-like emotion

GAIN: protects transcendence and removes false models.

COST: unlimited negation risks VACUITY and cannot distinguish God from nothing.

ANSWER CONTROL: negative content is determinate exclusion, not empty silence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/25: Tillich: symbol and being-itself

SIGN -> conventional pointer; replaceable; does not participate.

SYMBOL -> points + PARTICIPATES + opens reality/self + transforms.

arises collectively; grows and may die

GOD -> not one being or highest being; symbolically disclosed as BEING-ITSELF.

FAILURE

finite bearer claims ultimacy -> IDOLATRY / DEMONIC distortion

unconstrained participation -> vague or circular reference

CAUTION

"God is being-itself" proposed as non-symbolic anchor

Tillich later modified it; interpretive status remains disputed.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/25: Ramsey, metaphor and myth

IAN RAMSEY: ordinary MODEL + QUALIFIER -> disclosure situation ("penny drops")

father + heavenly | cause + first | good + infinitely

qualifier stretches and corrects; it does not erase ordinary content

METAPHOR -> transfers a pattern imaginatively without literal identity

MYTH -> narrative organises identity, world and value

DISTINCTIONS

metaphor / myth are not identical to Tillichian participation

disclosure is not proof; public and doctrinal constraints remain necessary

PAYOFF: religious language is a stretched use of a common instrument.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/25: Austin and Evans: speech acts and self-involvement

J. L. AUSTIN

locutionary content -> what words/proposition say

illocutionary force -> act performed

perlocutionary effect -> consequence for hearer/community

EXAMPLES: "I take refuge" | baptism | vow | blessing | ritual resolve (saṃkalpa)

DONALD EVANS: SELF-INVOLVING speech commits speaker and constitutes relationship.

CONTROL

performative force does not cancel cognitive presuppositions

one proposition may be asserted, confessed, promised or recited ironically

TRAP: do not test every religious utterance only as detached description.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/25: Secular versus religious use

DIFFERENCE IS FUNCTIONAL, NOT LEXICAL.

AXIS	SECULAR CENTRE	RELIGIOUS CENTRE
function	describe/predict	worship/confess/bless/vow
reference	empirical particulars	transcendent / non-ostensible
verification	determinate procedures	contested/experiential/eschatological
logic/register	ordinary public use	symbol, paradox, liturgy, mantra
self-involvement	often detachable	characteristically committing

CONTINUITY

same words, ordinary logic and overlapping speech acts
secular oath can be performative; scripture can contain ordinary factual claims.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/25: Ayer and verification

A. J. AYER: synthetic factual meaning requires possible experiential confirmation.

strong verification -> conclusive (too strict)

weak verification -> probabilistic support still required

"God exists" -> no experience bears on it -> literally meaningless, not merely false.

OBJECTIONS

verification principle appears neither analytic nor empirically verified

excludes many historical, theoretical, ethical and modal claims

LESSON

evidence matters, but empirical testability cannot simply equal all meaning.

NEXT MOVE: falsification asks what would count AGAINST the assertion.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 13/25: Flew, Hare, Mitchell and Hick

ANTHONY FLEW / invisible gardener

endless qualifications -> claim "dies" if nothing counts against it

R. M. HARE / paranoid student

blik = non-factual world-orientation; important without hypothesis-status

BASIL MITCHELL / partisan and Stranger

defeasible trust; adverse evidence genuinely counts but may be outweighed

JOHN HICK / celestial city

truth-apt now; eschatological verification at journey's end

CONTROL

Hare != Mitchell; Hick != present verification; resilient faith != immunity.

KEY TEST: what evidence changes warrant, interpretation or commitment?

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 14/25: The ten-point cognitive spectrum

1 strong literal realism -> Alston / Swinburne

2 analogical realism -> Aquinas

3 symbolic realism -> Tillich / Ramsey

4 eschatological realism -> Hick

5 mixed speech act -> Evans / Alston

6 meaning-in-use -> Wittgensteinian / Phillips [classification disputed]

7 moral-conative -> Braithwaite

8 attitudinal blik -> Hare

9 fictionalism / non-realism -> Cupitt / Le Poidevin

10 hostile elimination -> Ayer

VERDICT: spectrum, not binary; locate truth-aptness, reference and primary force.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 15/25: Braithwaite: moral policy and stories

R. B. BRAITHWAITE, An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief (1955).
"GOD IS LOVE" -> avowal of AGAPEISTIC MORAL POLICY.
STORIES -> exemplary patterns + motivation; practical seriousness preserved.
GAIN
 creed/conduct link; self-involvement; religion not meaningless
COST
 believers intend realist reference too
 secular agape possible without theology
 prayer, lament, creation and resurrection are not one moral policy
VERDICT: valuable pragmatics; reductionist as total semantics.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 16/25: Wittgensteinian grammar and Phillips

LUDWIG WITTGENSTEIN'S LECTURES
 Last Judgement belief != ordinary weather prediction
 use orients repentance, hope, fear and a life
LATER TERMS
 language-game | grammar | form of life
D. Z. PHILLIPS
 resisted simple non-cognitivist and reductionist labels
GAIN: prevents category mistakes and attends to context.
COST: FIDEISM / insulation if internal use excludes evidence and moral criticism.
REPLY: practices overlap; clarification does not itself validate truth.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 17/25: Advaita: Brahman and māyā

BRAHMAN
 real (sat), non-objectifiable, beyond ordinary predication
 "whence words turn back" (Taittiriya 2.9)
 ineffable / avācya; NOT neither-real-nor-unreal
MĀYĀ / WORLD-APPEARANCE
 appears -> not sheer unreality
 sublated by knowledge -> not ultimate reality
 therefore different from real and unreal (sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa)
 technically indeterminable (anirvacanīya)
TRAP: never collapse Brahman's ineffability into māyā's category-status.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 18/25: Advaita operations and Indian boundaries

NEGATION (neti neti; Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6) -> removes limiting predicates.
INDIRECT INDICATION (lakṣaṇā) -> intended import when literal sense fails.
PART-DISCARDING INDICATION (bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā)
 tat tvam asi -> discard incompatible connotations; retain consciousness.
OTHER BOUNDED STRATEGIES
 Rāmānuja -> real auspicious attributes
 Madhyamaka -> conventional meaning without intrinsic nature
 Jain conditional predication (syādvāda) -> state the respect
 Nyāya -> limited heuristic near univocity; not Scotus's doctrine
 Mīmāṃsā -> injunction (vidhi), mantra, eternity of word (śabda-nityatva)
 grammarians/Bhartr̥hari -> classical sphoṭa; NOT a Mīmāṃsā doctrine.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 19/25: Symbolism toward mysticism

AFFIRMATIVE ROUTE

- symbol participates
 - > practice draws subject in
 - > bearer becomes transparent
 - > SELF-EFFACEMENT
 - > claimed immediacy / mysticism

WEST

- Paul Ricoeur: symbol gives rise to thought; second naïveté
- Pseudo-Dionysius: cataphatic -> apophatic -> silence

INDIA

- symbol/image meditation (pratīka/pratimā upāsana)
- Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad: Om A-U-M -> waking/dream/deep sleep
- > soundless fourth (amātra/turiya)
- Tantra: mantra / yantra / maṇḍala internalised and dissolved

COMPARATIVE BRIDGE

- Eliade: hierophany | Sufi allusive signs (ishārāt)

CONTROL: structured route, not logical guarantee.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 20/25: Counter-case to symbolism-mysticism

1 ARREST

- literalised symbol claims ultimacy -> idolatry / demonic

2 CONSTITUTION

- Steven Katz: inherited symbols shape experience from the start

3 DELETION

- Zen / neti neti advance through iconoclasm or subtraction

4 NON-NECESSITY

- ethics, inquiry (manana), attention and grace are other routes

5 RETURN

- mystic communicates again through culturally formed symbols

VERDICT: normal and powerful route; neither necessary nor sufficient.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 21/25: The pluralism bridge

SEMANTICS -> epistemic access -> rival descriptions -> pluralism/exclusivism.

UNIVOCAL LITERALISM

- direct commensurability -> contradiction -> exclusivist pressure

ANALOGY / SYMBOL / APOPHASIS

- finite descriptions non-exhaustive -> pluralism intelligible

HICK

- transcategorical Real + personae/impersonae -> semantic thesis
- cost: vacuity; an empty Real cannot ground worship or discriminate traditions

INDIAN

- Advaita: unqualified/qualified (nirguṇa/saguṇa)
- Jainism: standpoint marked in assertion (syādvāda)

LIMIT: creator/no-creator and survival/no-survival remain hard contradictions.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 22/25: Inter-thinker debate and standing criticisms

AQUINAS -> realism / indeterminacy
SCOTUS -> inference / anthropomorphism or onto-theology charge
MAIMONIDES -> transcendence / vacuity
TILLICH -> depth / vague referent and self-reference
AYER-FLEW -> evidence / over-restriction
BRAITHWAITE -> practice / reductionism
WITTGENSTEINIAN -> context / insulation
ADVAITA -> non-objectification / self-reference and silence
OPTIONAL HISTORY -> Radical Orthodoxy links Scotist univocity to secular metaphysics;
the genealogy is contested, not established history
STANDING CRITICISMS
anthropomorphism | agnosticism | fideism | reductionism | self-reference
RULE: state objection exactly where the theory's mechanism produces it.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 23/25: PYQ map: 2018-2021

2018 Q5(a) [10] secular vs religious use -> function/referent/self-involvement.
2018 Q7(b) [15] Braithwaite -> policy/stories + reductionism.
2018 Q8(c) [15] symbols mediate transcendent referent -> cultural/spatial/temporal.
2019 Q6(a) [20] whether AND how symbolism leads to mysticism -> route + negative case.
2020 Q8(a) [20] cognitive content -> spectrum + evidence + mixed verdict.
2021 Q8(a) [20] non-cognitive/Braithwaite -> family + distinct account + critique.
2021 Q8(c) [15] Tillich -> sign/symbol, participation, being-itself, caution.
CONTROL: exact wording; independent models; no official answer key.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 24/25: PYQ map: 2022-2025

2022 Q5(e) [10] "God exists" -> apply cognitive/non-cognitive directly.
2023 Q5(d) [10] Wittgenstein -> use/form of life + qualification.
2023 Q7(c) [15] Tillich -> complete mechanism + objection.
2024 Q5(e) [10] analogy -> dilemma + res/modus + Scotus.
2024 Q8(a) [20 = 10+10] -> distinction first; contradiction/Braithwaite second.
2025 Q5(b) [10] symbolic? -> yes-but reasons + justification.
2025 Q8(c) [15] Advaitic anirvacanīyatā -> māyā/Brahman + semantic operations.
CONTROL: obey printed marks split and named-thinker fidelity.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 25/25: Examiner traps, answer spine and qualified conclusion

TRAPS

analogy != metaphor | symbol != sign | non-cognitive != meaningless
Ayer != Braithwaite != Hare != Wittgensteinian use
Tillich's being-itself exception is disputed
Scotus semantic != ontological univocity
Brahman ineffability != māyā's anirvacanīyatā
Mīmāṃsā's śabda-nīyatva != Bhartṛhari's sphoṭa

ANSWER SPINE

identify HOW/WHETHER -> define mechanism -> named evidence
-> explain what it proves -> strongest objection -> reply -> residual cost

CLAIM PARAGRAPH

claim -> text/thinker/example -> analysis -> qualification

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION

intelligible reference + apophatic humility + practical force
+ critical vulnerability = defensible mixed realism.